

NFO PERIOD
7TH TO 20TH AUGUST 2026



Know more

MAGNUM
SIF

OFFERED BY SBI MUTUAL FUND

Backed by Expertise.
Built for You.

Presenting our 2nd Investment Strategy

Magnum Equity Ex-Top 100
Long Short Fund

The Magnum Equity Ex-Top 100 Long Short Fund focuses on companies beyond India's top 100 by market capitalisation, providing access to wider and evolving opportunities across mid and small cap companies. Using a core-satellite design with a structured long-short approach, the fund is designed to navigate market movements. As an equity oriented SIF strategy, it also offers equity taxation benefits.



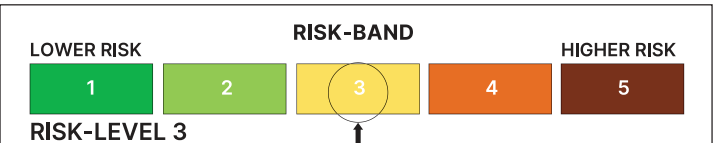
Invest with
InvesTap Nxt

Magnum Equity Ex-Top 100 Long Short Fund is an open ended investment strategy predominantly investing in equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments, of stocks other than large cap stocks.

This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*:

- Long-term capital appreciation
- An open-ended investment strategy investing in equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments, of stocks other than large cap stocks.

Strategy Risk-band



*Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.

Benchmark Risk-band
BSE 500 TRI



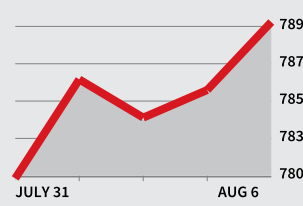
The above product labelling assigned during the New Fund Offer (NFO) is based on internal assessment of the characteristics of the investment strategy or model portfolio and the same may vary post NFO when the actual investments are made. In view of individual circumstances and risk profiles, investors are advised to consult their investment and/or tax advisers before making any investment decisions.

Toll-free: 1800 209 3333 | Contact your MFD/RIA | www.sbimf.com/magnumsif | Follow us: f X y i n

Investments in Specialized Investment Fund involves relatively higher risk including potential loss of capital, liquidity risk and market volatility. Please read all investment strategy related documents carefully before making the investment decision.

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78954.76 (+373.76)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24636.00	+11.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.00	+0.10
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.22	+0.11
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	147846.00	+2803
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	225674.00	+1112

BITTER SURPRISE.

Sugar poised to rule lower this quarter despite prices topping 15 US cents/pound on the InterContinental Exchange **p10**



HEALTHY BET.

KKR has signed a deal with Medcover to acquire the latter's India arm for \$1.5b **p2**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

GOBARDHAN

Approval for ₹23,731-cr bioenergy scheme



New Delhi: The Cabinet on Thursday approved GOBARDHAN, or the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme, with a total outlay of ₹23,731 crore. The scheme aims to address long-standing bottlenecks such as assured offtake, stable pricing and evacuation infrastructure. It intends to increase domestic compressed biogas production nearly ten-fold and mobilise largescale private investments. **p11**

TECH LOSING CHARM

Share of fresher hires in IT drops to 24% in July

Bengaluru: India's technology hiring story is splitting into two distinct trends. While the demand for technology professionals grew 10 per cent over the past year, the IT industry's share of fresher hiring dropped sharply from 32 per cent to 24 per cent, according to foundit insights tracker for July 2026. **p9**

Tata Sons listing hinges on RBI's de-registration call

BIG IF. Tata holding co remains NBFC-UL, but RBI looking at its de-registration application

Aneesh Phadnis
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

The RBI's latest list of non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) in the upper layer for 2026-27 has once again put the spotlight on Tata Sons and revived a key question: Will the holding company eventually have to list, or could it get regulatory relief? The RBI notification retained Tata Sons in the upper layer NBFC category as a core investment company (CIC), while clarifying that its inclusion is "without prejudice" to the outcome of its de-registration application, which is still under examination.

REGULATORY NORMS

The issue is significant because entities classified in the upper layer are subject to enhanced regulatory requirements under the RBI's scale-based framework. Public listing has been widely seen as one of the obligations associated with this category. Tata Sons, however, has sought to exit the NBFC

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- RBI de-registration decision remains crucial
- NBFC-UL tag linked to standalone asset size threshold of ₹1 lakh crore
- Income restructuring remains a fallback option, but is impractical and unlikely
- RBI decision could set future precedent



framework, arguing that it no longer requires such a regulatory classification.

Legal experts say the RBI's decision on de-registration will ultimately determine whether listing becomes inevitable. If the regulator concludes that Tata Sons no longer qualifies as an NBFC requiring upper layer supervision, the listing issue could effectively disappear. Conversely, if the company continues to be classified as an NBFC-UL, any exemption from regulatory requirements would need to be backed by legal reasoning. Nazneen Ichhaporia, Part-

ner, ANB Legal, said: "Tata Sons' de-registration application remains its strongest option and, in my view, holds merit as it predates the new norms. While restructuring its income streams could be an alternative, that would be contrary to its role as the Tata Group's holding company. If the RBI rejects the request, compliance with NBFC-UL requirements may be unavoidable."

STATUS, THE KEY

"The RBI must first determine whether Tata Sons still qualifies for upper layer NBFC supervision. That reg-

ulatory finding comes before any listing requirement. If its NBFC status changes, the listing question could also change because listing flows from regulatory classification, not vice-versa," said Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates.

Chandwani added that the larger issue is one of regulatory certainty and equal treatment. "If the RBI decides that Tata Sons should remain an upper layer NBFC but exempts it from a core compliance requirement, it would have to articulate a legally sustainable rationale. Otherwise, similarly placed entities could legitimately argue that equal regulatory treatment has not been maintained."

For Tata Sons, de-registration is crucial as it sees itself as the Tata Group's investment and philanthropic holding company, rather than a lending-focused financial institution.

Until the RBI rules on its application, however, it remains subject to NBFC-UL regulations.

See p7

MDR of less than 0.25% on P2M UPI deals can compensate stakeholders

Lokeshwarri SK
Chennai

A provision in the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill 2026, followed by Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra's statement on Wednesday, has raised the possibility of the Centre levying Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions soon.

MDR is a fee charged by banks and payment processing companies on merchants for each credit and debit transaction.

What can be the optimum rate at which the banks, payment service providers as well as NPCI, the infrastructure provider, can be adequately compensated?

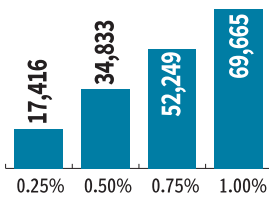
THE RIGHT RATE

UPI transactions consist of person-to-person (P2P) and person-to-merchant (P2M) payments. The thinking seems to be to target P2M transactions alone.

Currently, of these, P2M transactions account for only 29 per cent of the total value of all UPI payments, according to a Finance Ministry release.

If we apply a filter, say, transactions of more than ₹2,000 each, then around 67

The optimum MDR
Merchant Discount Rate realisable Chargeable at



Source: bl analysis

per cent of all P2M payments will be covered. That would have accounted for ₹5,80,568 crore in July alone, going by the latest available data.

The total value of UPI transactions in July was ₹29.88 lakh crore.

Extrapolating July data for the whole year and assuming a small 0.25 per cent MDR on P2M payments of more than ₹2,000, the MDR yield will be ₹17,416 crore annually.

MDR of 0.5 per cent will give ₹34,833 crore, MDR of 0.75 per cent will get ₹52,249 crore and 1 per cent ₹69,665 crore.

WHAT IS THE COST?

Currently, the Centre gives banks and other payment service providers an incentive for providing UPI service. For FY27, ₹2,000 crore

was set aside in the Union Budget for the incentive scheme for promotion of RuPay debit cards and low-value BHIM-UPI transactions. The revised estimate for FY26 was ₹2,196 crore.

NPCI's financial statement for FY25 shows that it spent ₹742 crore towards capital expenditure.

This spend is not just for UPI, but also for other payment systems such as IMPs, Bharat Bill Pay and Pastag.

While there will be revenue expenses to account for, NPCI's net profit margin was 36 per cent in FY25.

COST INCURRED

According to an RBI discussion paper of 2022, the total cost incurred by banks, app providers and NPCI for each P2M transaction equals 0.25 per cent of the transaction value.

But the above analysis shows that an MDR of less than 0.25 per cent may be enough to compensate all stakeholders adequately at this juncture.

Of course, there is reliable data on spending by banks on servicing UPI payments. Yet, the fact is that banks do benefit from higher savings account balances maintained by customers to service their UPI payments.



This pictorial representation of map of India does not purport to be the political map of India. Map not to scale.

FAST-TRACKING GROWTH BY SERVING INDIA'S EVER-GROWING EV MARKET.

As one of India's leading electrical and electronic companies, we are future-driven.

- One of India's leading electrical & electronics (E&E) companies.*
- One of India's top 2 players in wiring harnesses for two & three wheelers.*
- A diversified presence across multiple end markets, including commercial vehicles, off-highway vehicles, farming & industrial equipment.
- 22 manufacturing facilities, 3 engineering and design support centers & 7 warehouses across India and globally.**
- Providing access to major automotive clusters both in India & the world over.

*Source: CRISIL Report | ** As of March 31, 2026

DHOOT TRANSMISSION
Harnessing Safety, Electrifying The Future

Dhoot Transmission Limited

www.dhoottransmission.com

DHOOT TRANSMISSION LIMITED, is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP dated August 3, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP and Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, as well as on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.dhoottransmission.com and on the websites of the BRLMs, i.e. Axis Capital Limited, Jefferies India Private Limited, Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited, Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited, SBI Capital Markets Limited and 360 ONE WAM Limited at www.axiscapital.co.in, www.jefferies.com, [https://investmentbank.kotak.com](http://investmentbank.kotak.com), www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html, www.sbicaps.com and www.360.one, respectively. Any potential Bidders should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" on page 24 of the RHP. Potential Bidders should not rely on the UDRHP-I filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment decision and should instead rely on the RHP, when filed, for making an investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the United States Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any other applicable law of the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold (a) within the United States only to persons reasonably believed to be "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act and referred to in the RHP as "U.S. QIBs"), for the avoidance of doubt, the term "U.S. QIBs" does not refer to a category of institutional investor defined under applicable Indian regulations and referred to in the RHP as "QIBs") in transactions exempt from, or not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act; and (b) outside of the United States in offshore transactions as defined in and in compliance with Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act ("Regulation S") and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales are made. It is to be distinctly understood that the permission given by Stock Exchanges should not in any way be deemed or construed that the Offer Document has been cleared or approved by Stock Exchanges nor does it certify the correctness or completeness of any of the contents of the Offer Document. The investors are advised to refer to the Offer Document for the full text of the Disclaimer Clause of NSE and BSE Limited.

QUICKLY.

Reliance Power Q1 PAT jumps 44% to ₹65 crore



Ahmedabad: Reliance Power reported a 44 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated net profit to ₹65 crore for the quarter ended June, helped by steady operating performance despite ongoing legal and financial challenges at some of its subsidiaries. Revenue from operations rose 4 per cent to ₹1,956 crore during the quarter. The company said it had fully cooperated with the recent searches conducted by the CBI at the registered offices of Reliance Power and Reliance Cleangen Ltd. Meanwhile, it also disclosed continuing financial stress at two subsidiaries. **OUR BUREAU**

Volume growth lifts Britannia Q1 PAT by 14%



Bengaluru: Britannia Industries posted a 14 per cent year-on-year rise in first-quarter net profit to ₹593 crore, aided by healthy volume growth, market share gains, and strong traction in e-commerce and general trade. The performance comes even as higher fuel and freight costs stemming from the West Asia conflict weighed on operations. The consolidated sales for the quarter rose 9.5 per cent y-o-y to ₹4,964 crore. Most key categories saw positive sequential momentum with Britannia posting a mid-teens revenue growth. **OUR BUREAU**

Biocon bets on new US drugs for stronger H2

STAR PRODUCT. Biosimilar for eye injection alone rakes in \$3 b

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Biocon expects a stronger second half of FY27 as its recent biosimilar launches in the US have begun contributing meaningfully to revenues.

In a post-results press conference in Bengaluru on Thursday, Shreehas Tambe, CEO and Managing Director of the company, pointed to the five recent product launches in the US, including biosimilar aflibercept (Yesafili), denosumab biosimilars Bosaya and Ankelso and generic liraglutide, which could gain from the favourable regulatory changes in the market.

LARGE MARKET

The company, which reported a 10 per cent increase in its June quarter consolidated revenue to ₹4,336 crore from the year-ago period, said the momentum from multiple product launches will be-



GROWTH STRATEGY. The Biocon management expects to continue focusing on its product mix while maintaining R&D spends at around 7 per cent of revenue

come more visible over the coming quarters.

Tambe said the Yesafili, the biosimilar to Eylea (an eye injection), addresses a market worth roughly \$3 billion in the US alone. While concerns existed around physician adoption because the therapy is injected into the retina, he said those fears had largely dissipated following a successful launch by an earlier biosimilar entrant.

Beyond product launches, he said recent changes in the US regulatory framework

could benefit companies with proven capabilities to develop biosimilars. The US regulator's move away from mandatory phase-3 comparative efficacy trials places greater emphasis on analytical and pharmacokinetic studies, an area where incumbent players such as Biocon already have significant experience.

Tambe said the company will continue focusing on its product mix while maintaining R&D spending at around 7 per cent of revenue.

KKR to acquire Medcover India for \$1.5 billion

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Global investment firm KKR has signed a definitive agreement with Medcover AB, an international healthcare and diagnostic-service provider to acquire the latter's India arm for \$1.5 billion (₹14,280 crore).

Medcover India, established in 2017, operates a multi-specialty hospital network with 24 centres and about 4,800 beds across South and West India.

The company provides



comprehensive care across over 80 clinical specialities, supported by more than 1,900 doctors and advanced clinical infrastructure and technology, serving millions of patients.

KKR is looking forward to contributing to Medcover India's next phase by investing behind its talent, technology, infrastructure and clinical capabilities, while reinforcing strong clinical governance and operational standards, said Akshay Tanna, Partner and Head of India Private Equity at KKR.

STEADY INVESTMENTS

The investor believes sustained investment in healthcare infrastructure, clinical capabilities, technology, and innovation will help strengthen the delivery of

Deceptive trade: CCPA slaps ₹20 lakh fine on FirstCry, Zepto, five others

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has imposed penalties amounting to ₹20 lakh on seven e-commerce platforms, including Zepto and Physicwallah, for indulging in "dark pattern" practices to manipulate choices for consumers.

"Subsequent to the Guidelines for the Prevention Dark Pattern 2023, CCPA has taken action against e-commerce platforms engaging in dark patterns," Minister of State for Food and Consumer Affairs BL Verma said in a written reply to the Rajya Sabha.

DRIP PRICING

Besides the two companies mentioned above, Anuj Jindal, FirstCry, PharmaEasy, McAfee and SpiceJet have been penalised while notices were served to two companies, namely InterGlobe Aviation and BookMyShow.

Zepto was penalised ₹7 lakh for using drip pricing and basket sneaking.

Centre spent over ₹187 crore on PM Modi's foreign visits in 2025

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

The government spent ₹187.83 crore on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's overseas visits alone in 2025, Pabitra Margherita, the Minister of State for External Affairs, stated in a response to an unstarred question in the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

The expenditure was driven by an intensive travel schedule that covered 23 countries, the Minister added in his response.

DATA FOCUS.

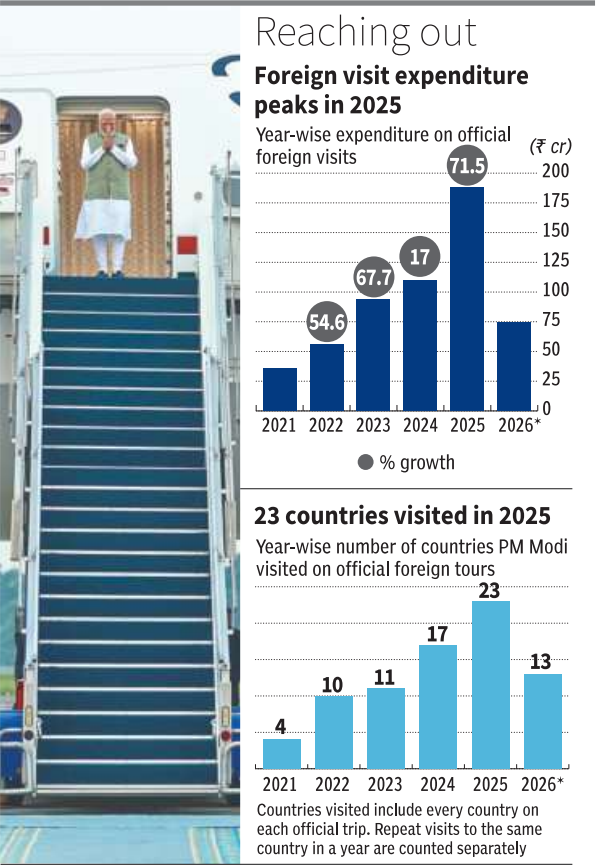
This was 71.5 per cent higher than the ₹109.51 crore the government spent on the Prime Minister's foreign travel in 2024, and more than five-fold the expenditure incurred in 2021, when overseas engagements remained limited following the Covid-19 pandemic.

ISING COSTS

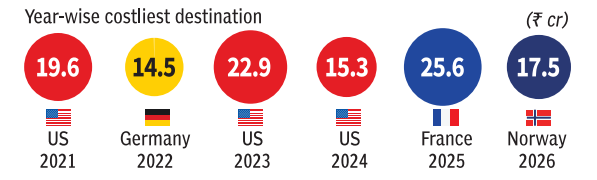
In 2026, the spending has already crossed ₹74.5 crore as of July, although the government said the final cost of Modi's visit to France in June was yet to be compiled.

The number of countries covered through the Prime Minister's official foreign visits have also risen steadily over the period. While Modi visited four countries in 2021, he travelled to 10 in 2022, 11 in 2023, 17 in 2024, and 23 in 2025. Till July this year, he has visited 13 countries (repeat visits to the same country are counted separately).

The data also show that a few destinations accounted for a significant share of annual travel expenditure for the country. For instance, the France leg of Modi's 2025 visit, the costliest overseas travel in the past five years, resulted in agreements on start-up collaboration, environmental cooperation, advanced and small modular reactors, digital sciences, tri-



US tops as the costliest destination in half the years since 2021



Source: Rajya Sabha

*Up to July

angular development operation and nuclear training.

Visits to the US, the costliest destination in three of the six years covered by the data, saw agreements on healthcare and infectious disease research, semiconductor supply chains, jet engine cooperation, the Artemis Accords, and the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework's Clean Economy, Fair Economy and overarching agreements.

Modi's visits to Germany

saw him sign agreements on green and sustainable development, renewable energy, green hydrogen, migration and mobility, among other things. For 2026, the Norway leg of the Prime Minsiter's visit has so far been the most expensive, with an expenditure of ₹17.47 crore.

The government, however, noted that the final expenditure for some destinations, including France and Norway, remain subject to the settlement of pending bills.

Pidilite passes on raw material cost impact, Q1 profit rises 30%

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Pidilite Industries has managed to pass on the incremental rise in raw material prices triggered by the escalation in the West Asia conflict.

In the quarter ended June, the adhesives and construction chemicals company raised prices across its consumer and bazaar portfolio between 2 per cent and 12 per cent. Industrial products saw steeper hikes.

During the quarter, the company posted a 30 per cent rise in net profit to ₹884 crore from the year before, while consolidated revenue increased 21 per cent to ₹4,551 crore. It was driven by sustained demand, proactive pricing, and operating leverage from higher sales, said Sudhanshu Vats, Managing



Sudhanshu Vats, Managing Director, Pidilite Industries

Director. "We delivered an underlying volume growth of 11 per cent, supported by disciplined execution and timely price increases. We also benefitted from low-cost inventory carried from the previous quarter and managed costs effectively while continuing to invest in our brands," he added.

COST RECOVERY

Pidilite's pricing strategy, he stressed, aims to recover increases in raw material costs

rather than expanding margins. "Our philosophy is to pass on only the absolute increase in costs while absorbing part of the inflation ourselves." The company indicated that if raw material prices were to soften further, it will pass on the benefit through trade rebates.

To reduce supply-chain risks, the company has diversified its sourcing across multiple suppliers and geographies, eliminating dependence on single-source vendors. It has also created buffer stocks of packaging material feedstock to support suppliers.

On demand trends, he said, urban markets outperformed during the quarter, while rural demand also remained healthy. For FY27, Pidilite reiterated its expectation of delivering double-digit underlying volume growth.

Dabur watchful of headwinds, targets double-digit growth in FY27

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



Dabur India on Thursday said that while the overall consumption environment remained "stable", it continues to be influenced by weather-related issues, inflationary trends, and geopolitical developments.

Speaking at the company's 51st annual general meeting, Mohit Malhotra, Global CEO of the company, said, "For FY27, we are targeting a double-digit growth in consolidated revenue, subject to the geopolitical environment."

"While inflationary pressures, including volatility in crude-linked inputs and packaging material, remain a watch area, we will continue to pursue a balanced approach of judicious price increases and cost efficiency initiatives to protect and improve our profitability," he said. "Our focus remains on sustaining healthy growth

while maintaining an appropriate balance between volume expansion and pricing net growth."

The executive added that rural demand remained resilient and continued to outperform urban markets, and urban demand is expected to improve gradually.

GOOD OPPORTUNITIES

"India continues to be one of the most exciting consumer markets in the world. Rising aspirations, increasing premiumisation, growing digital adoption, and a renewed focus on health and wellness are creating significant opportunities for companies like Dabur," said

Mohit Burman, the company's Chairman. The company said its premium portfolio was growing at a faster clip, too.

PRICE PRESSURES

Responding to shareholder queries, Malhotra said geopolitical developments in West Asia had impacted the performance of the company

in certain Middle East and North Africa (MENA) markets and led to supply-chain disruptions across the region.

To mitigate these challenges, he said the company had been strengthening alternative supply routes, including sourcing from India for the US and MENA markets.

... moves court against FSSAI's prohibition order

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Dabur India approached the Delhi High Court on Thursday challenging the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI) prohibition of sale order for some of its products carrying 100 per cent claims.

On Monday, the FSSAI directed the FMCG major to immediately cease the sale of food products, including

honey, apple cider vinegar, virgin coconut oil, sesame oil, cow ghee, coconut water, and coconut milk, among others. In a social media post, the regulator said it had found the products were being sold on Dabur's website and were in contravention of its 2018 regulations.

In a BSE filing, the company had earlier said most of the affected products were either already transitioned to revised labels and advertisements

without such claims or are in the process of doing so.

On Thursday, responding to shareholder queries during its AGM, Dabur said it was committed to the highest standards of product quality, purity and food safety.

USFDA LETTER

On the issue of the US drug regulator shooting a letter to the company, Dabur said there was no financial, operational or other impact due to it.

Trent's Q1 profit jumps 26%, revenue hits ₹5,666 crore on store expansion

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Trent Ltd, the Tata Group's retail arm, reported a 26 per cent year-on-year rise in standalone net profit to ₹532 crore for the first quarter of FY27. Standalone revenue from operations grew 19 per cent to ₹5,666 crore, while consolidated revenue rose 18 per cent to ₹5,755 crore during the period.

The company's operating profitability improved

sharply, with standalone EBIT expanding 33 per cent from the year-ago period to ₹732 crore.

On a consolidated basis, Trent's profit after tax came in at ₹518 crore, rising 22 per cent from the June quarter of FY26.

The company ended the quarter with 1,312 stores across 330 cities, including three in the UAE.

BRAND REVENUES

The company opened 22 new Zudio stores and one Westside store during the quarter, while consolidating three Zudio locations. Zudio's total store count reached 982, while Westside's stood at 301. Over 80 per cent of Zudio's new store additions were in tier-2 and tier-3 cities and peripheral micro-markets.

Online revenues for Westside, across its platform and

Tata Neu, crossed 6 per cent of the brand's total revenues. Emerging categories including beauty and personal care, innerwear and footwear collectively contributed over 21 per cent of fashion revenue.

TACKLING INPUT COSTS

Like-for-like growth for the fashion portfolio, however, remained in the low single digits.

The management acknowledged rising input costs in select categories and said it was addressing them through supply-chain interventions and price architecture calibration.

The food and grocery business, Star, reported revenues of ₹885 crore for the quarter, while it added five stores, taking the total count to 86 across 12 cities.

Trent's stock closed at ₹3,107.10 on Thursday, well below its 52-week high.

Emami Agrotech eyes a pie of India's snacking market, to invest ₹750 crore

Our Bureau
Kolkata



Emami Group's food and agri-business arm Emami Agrotech on Thursday announced its entry into the country's ₹50,000-crore packaged snacking market. The company plans to invest around ₹750 crore in the next three years to grow the new high-margin product categories.

As part of making its snacking brand "WeMe" a ₹1,000-crore brand in the next five to seven years, the company also aims to target younger generations, particularly Gen Z and Millennials.

India's snacking market, led by chips, is growing at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of over 8 per cent and is expected to reach over ₹1 lakh crore by 2034.

The company currently

outsources the production of three newly-launched categories — choco hazelnut spread, potato chips and *jhuri aloo bhaja* (deep-fried potato sticks).

It is also planning to set up an integrated greenfield manufacturing plant for the snacking products and staples in West Bengal in the next two years.

BRANDING PUSH

"We will invest around ₹400 crore for the plant. And, ₹350 crore will be spent on branding and marketing for the

newly-launched products," said Aditya Vardhan Agarwal, Director, Emami Group.

Emami Agrotech had entered into the branded staples market last year with the launch of *maida*, *atta* and *suji*. Explaining the entry into the snacking market now, Agarwal said margins in these product categories were much higher than that of staple products.

Emami Group Director Vidula Agarwal, who is spearheading the initiative, said the new products are being launched in West Bengal first and that they will be rolled out nationally in phases.

"WeMe has been built as a digital-first brand where content, commerce and consumer engagement come together seamlessly. This distribution strategy will enable us to make it instantly accessible across key cities," he added.

Lumina Datamatics closes acquisition of TNQTech

Our Bureau
Chennai

Lumina Datamatics, a content, retail support and technology-solutions company, has completed the acquisition of TNQTech, a Chennai-based publishing technology company. The transaction positions the combined organisation among the world's largest providers of scholarly publishing solutions and is a key milestone in Lumina's growth journey, a company statement said.

The move follows the signing of a definitive agreement between the parties in late 2024 for an 80 per cent controlling stake in TNQTech.

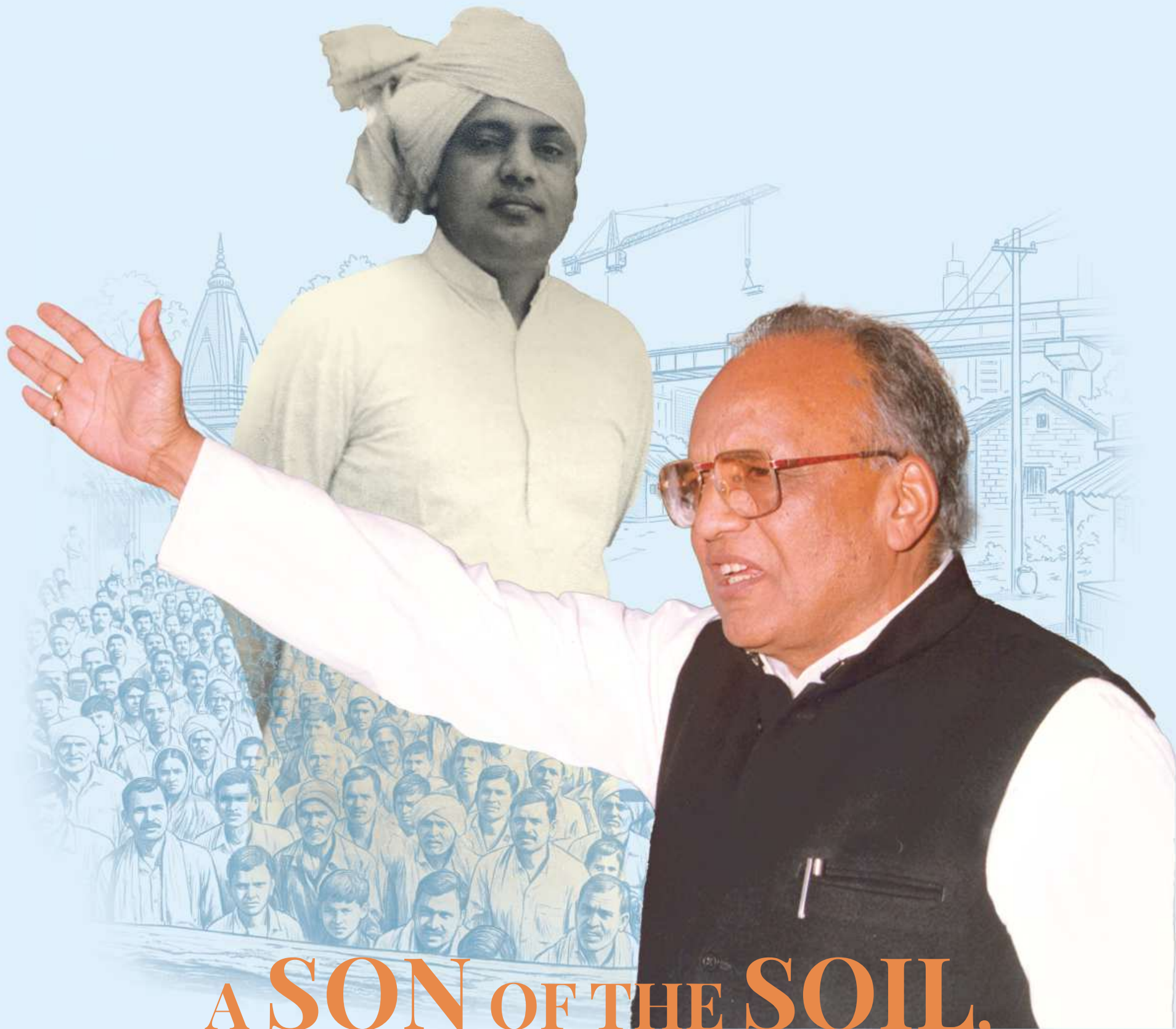
With the total acquisition now complete, TNQTech becomes a wholly-owned subsidiary of Lumina Datamatics. "Together, we have created a leading global partner for scholarly publishing solu-

tions, combining deep domain expertise with next-generation AI technologies, to help publishers transform their businesses," said Sameer Kanodia, Vice-Chairman and CEO of Lumina Datamatics.

Mariam Ram, Founder and Director, TNQTech, said, "Our technology and domain expertise align perfectly with their scale and reach in scholarly publishing. I am confident TNQTech's people, products and customers are now in the hands of a reliable, trusted organisation that will carry our vision forward while driving the next phase of innovation and growth."

The combined entity can support publishers across the entire content lifecycle — from manuscript submission and peer review to production, digital publishing, accessibility, analytics and AI-powered content enrichment.

#RememberingBauji



A SON OF THE SOIL, A LEADER WHO SHAPED SOCIETY

7TH AUGUST 1930 ~ 31ST MARCH 2005

Shri O.P. Jindal never saw barriers. He saw possibilities waiting to be unlocked. A son of the soil, a visionary, and a nation-builder, he opened doors to new horizons of development—expanded access to education, promoted affordable healthcare, and pioneered employment opportunities in rural India. He transformed countless lives, and helped build our India.

On his 96th Birth Anniversary, we remember a legacy that continues to inspire generations.



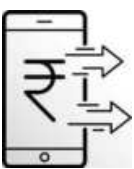
SCAN THIS QR CODE
TO WATCH THE VIDEO



No free rides

Small levy on UPI transactions, not a bad idea

The Unified Payments Interface is one of the mascots of India’s digital success. Since its launch in 2016, it has become the world’s largest real-time payments platform accounting for nearly half of global real-time payments. Now, it may not remain free to users for long, as is implied in the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026. The proposed change is not without basis. As with all public services, the user should pay at least a bit to keep the system going.



The Bill allows the Centre to notify payment systems where MDR can be levied. Banks will collect the MDR from merchants for distribution to payment processors and National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), the entity managing this ecosystem. With UPI use having picked up rapidly, the costs of providing the service too need to be considered, in the form of upkeep and investments. As Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra has noted, someone must bear this cost. The Centre (or NPCI) has been doing so, but cannot carry on beyond a point. With banks charging MDR on other payment options such as debit and credit cards, the same is justified on UPI transactions as well. The Centre has so far been bearing part of the cost of running the payments system through its incentive scheme for promoting low value person-to-merchant transactions through RuPay debit cards and UPI. It spent ₹2,196 crore on this scheme in FY26 and has set aside ₹2,000 crore for FY27. Banks, however, should not be complaining here. They say that the government incentive is insufficient to cover their costs; yet they benefit from the growth in low interest CASA (current and savings account) deposits used for UPI transactions. But NPCI, which operates and maintains the UPI system, needs to be compensated. Similarly, other payments processing companies in the UPI ecosystem will find it hard to sustain their business, if it remains free of charge.

While the consensus appears to be veering towards imposing MDR on P2M transactions, it is good that the policymakers are considering exempting low-value transactions. Transactions valued at less than ₹500 currently account for 86 per cent of volume while those between ₹500 and ₹2,000 account for 10 per cent. Making only transactions valued more than ₹2,000 liable to MDR levy will exempt 96 per cent of P2M transactions. This will ensure that the less affluent users do not pay for using UPI. Experience with other payments systems such as NEFT, IMPS, debt and credit cards show that additional service charge does not matter in large-value transactions.

But the timing is critical here. According to RBI, there is potential for the user base of UPI to double from the current level of 50 crore. Number of transactions per user is far below global levels. Besides, the annual growth in volume and value of transactions is also down from the exponential growth witnessed in initial years. The introduction of MDR should be delayed till the UPI attains irreversible scale.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



PRATEEK MITRAL

Here is an unfashionable thought: if the AI bubble bursts, India should be ready to celebrate. The bullish case for AI — argued most forcefully by the market’s boldest thinkers — is that this is not a contained technology story but a disruption that will remake every industry at once. They are right. But total disruption has a habit no one likes to mention: it eventually turns on the disruptors themselves. Economists call it creative destruction, capitalism tearing down the old to fund the new. A bust is not the opposite of progress; it is how progress clears its ground. The only question is who is standing in the right place when the dust settles.

The most instructive example is the one that built modern India. In 2000, the dot-com crash wiped out trillions. Telecom firms had spent the late nineties laying fibre-optic cable in a frenzy of overbuilding; when the crash came, they went bankrupt, but the fibre stayed in the ground, sold off for cents on the dollar. The price of moving data across the world collapsed. That cheap bandwidth financed the next 20 years: streaming, cloud, the smartphone internet and its biggest beneficiary was arguably India, whose IT boom was possible only because a transcontinental data line, once ruinously expensive, had become nearly free. An entire middle class was built on the wreckage of someone else’s bubble.

AI SPENDING

Now look at today. Global AI spending is racing past \$2.5 trillion this year, roughly half of it into data centres, chips, and power. The strain is already showing. The world’s most valuable chip stocks have seen more than \$1 trillion wiped from their market caps last week. The pattern is familiar: too much capacity, built too fast, on borrowed conviction.

So will the AI bust do for computing what the dot-com bust did for bandwidth? Likely. That is why the bust is generous, it floods the world with

AI is about to walk out of the screen and into the physical world — robots on factory floors, machines servicing other machines, systems running power grids and water plants



REUTERS

abundant, still-useful compute at a fraction of today’s cost. And yet cheap infrastructure has never, by itself, made anyone a winner. The firms that owned the fibre went bankrupt owning it. The winners took the cheap leftovers and redesigned the industry around them; Google reorganising the world’s information, Amazon rebuilding retail, cheap connectivity making software-as-a-service workable and cloud computing economical. None of it was the fibre; all of it was the redesign,

powered by a data asset nobody else had: Google’s searches, Amazon’s purchases. Infrastructure became the commodity. Scarce data became the empire.

The boom’s favourite belief is that AI models work better with more data. True for a while, but “more” quietly meant more of the same: internet text, images, video. That well is running dry; the web has been scraped to exhaustion, and every laboratory now holds the same corpus. Which is why the field’s own founders are in revolt. Yann LeCun, for 12 years Meta’s chief AI scientist, walked

CREATIVE DESTRUCTION. The AI crash will hand the world cheap compute and the winner will be whoever owns the data that was never on the internet

Next challenge for India’s digital lending revolution

Excessive unsecured credit and at high borrowing costs call for regulatory attention

Harsimran Sandhu

India’s digital lending revolution has transformed access to credit. Loans that once required lengthy paperwork and multiple visits to a bank branch can now be sanctioned within minutes through a smartphone. Millions of first-time borrowers have entered the formal financial system because of this innovation.

Yet this success has exposed an important regulatory gap. India has developed a comprehensive framework governing digital lending — covering disclosure, loan disbursal, data privacy, recovery practices and grievance redressal. However, two critical questions remain largely unanswered: how much a borrower ultimately pays for credit and how many simultaneous unsecured loans a borrower can accumulate. These have become the missing pillars of India’s digital credit architecture.

According to the Reserve Bank of India, personal loans account for 30.7 per cent of total bank credit, reflecting the rapid expansion of retail lending. Within this broader market, digital NBFCs account for 77 per cent of all personal loans sanctioned by volume, serving primarily young, first-time and thin-file borrowers through small-ticket loans. Digital credit is therefore no longer a niche product; it has become the principal gateway through which millions of Indians access formal finance. Financial inclusion, however, should not come at the expense of

financial protection. Many digital loans carry short repayment tenures and mandatory upfront charges. Although lenders disclose borrowing costs as required under RBI regulations, the effective cost of credit can differ materially once fees and loan structure are considered. Consequently, borrowers may not always appreciate the true economic cost of borrowing when making financial decisions.

BORROWING DECISIONS

The RBI’s regulatory framework rightly places considerable emphasis on transparency through disclosure. Yet disclosure assumes borrowers make informed and rational financial decisions after comparing loan costs. Behavioural economics suggests otherwise. Individuals seeking credit to meet medical emergencies, household expenses or temporary cash-flow shortages rarely optimise borrowing costs. Immediate liquidity needs, financial stress and present bias often dominate decision-making, reducing disclosure to a necessary, but not sufficient, consumer protection mechanism.

Pricing, however, is only part of the challenge. The current framework imposes virtually no restriction on the number of concurrent unsecured digital loans a borrower may obtain. Once one lender reaches its internal exposure limit, another lender may extend fresh credit. Credit bureau enquiries themselves can become signals for competing lenders to market additional loans. While every lender evaluates



DIGITAL CREDIT. No longer a niche product GETTY IMAGES

affordability independently, none necessarily assesses a borrower’s aggregate indebtedness across multiple lending platforms.

Borrower case studies demonstrate the consequences. Several households were servicing monthly instalments that exceeded their monthly incomes, forcing many to rely on fresh borrowing simply to repay existing loans. Although app-based loans often represented only a small share of total outstanding debt, they accounted for a disproportionately large share of monthly repayments because of their pricing and short repayment periods. This creates a cycle of repeated borrowing that can quickly become financially unsustainable.

The RBI has already acknowledged that excessive pricing warrants supervisory attention. In 2024, it prohibited four NBFCs from sanctioning fresh loans after finding their lending rates and spreads excessive. These actions demonstrate

that consumer protection concerns already form part of regulatory supervision. The next logical step is to complement supervisory interventions with clearer and more transparent market-wide standards.

This is entirely consistent with the RBI’s dual mandate. As the guardian of financial stability, it has moderated the growth of unsecured credit through macro-prudential measures. As India’s consumer protection regulator, however, it must also ensure that expanding access to credit does not expose vulnerable households to unsustainable debt.

The RBI already possesses broad statutory powers to regulate NBFCs, and the Supreme Court has reaffirmed that lending-rate regulation falls within its jurisdiction. The central bank has previously regulated lending rates in specific segments, demonstrating that intervention to address market failures is well within its policy mandate.

The next phase of digital lending regulation should therefore focus on two reforms. First, the RBI should establish prudential limits on the number of concurrent unsecured digital loans that a borrower may hold by leveraging the existing credit bureau infrastructure.

Second, it should provide greater regulatory clarity on what constitutes an excessive effective borrowing cost, considering all mandatory charges rather than relying solely on the stated interest rate.

The writer is Professor of finance, IMT Ghaziabad

✉ LETTERS TO EDITOR Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Inflation can spike

The comfort over moderating inflation overlooks gathering headwinds. Crude oil remains hostage to geopolitical shocks, climate volatility can swiftly revive food prices, and strong industrial growth coupled with rising credit demand could rekindle inflationary pressures. Externally, elevated global interest rates and a stronger dollar invite imported inflation. An upward bias would not have meant an immediate rate hike. It would simply have reaffirmed the RBI’s

inflation-fighting resolve and preserved policy flexibility before inflation demands action.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

UPI usage charges

This refers to ‘Service charge on UPI transactions makes sense’ (August 6). Maintaining a payment mechanism without charging the beneficiaries is a loss to all stakeholders who are part of the system. Remittance services in vogue in the banking space are not without

fees, irrespective of the size of transactions, except otherwise eligible. It is justified and imperative to leave small-value transactions out of the ambit of fees, but it is necessary to levy fees on transactions above some thresholds to compensate the stakeholders of the payment system. At this juncture, the importance of Central Bank Digital Currency to curb the cost involved in currency management is worth mentioning.

VSK Pillai
Changanacherry, Kerala

MDR framework

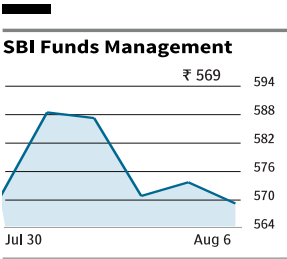
This refers to ‘UPI ecosystem needs sustainable funding: RBI Governor’ (August 6). The proposal to introduce MDR could become one of the most consequential policy decisions for India’s fintech ecosystem. Over the past few years, RBI-regulated fintech sector has increasingly gravitated towards lending rather than payments. The reason is structural, not strategic. In a zero-MDR regime, payments have become a low-margin business, while lending offers a viable path to

monetisation. It is therefore no surprise that even companies with dominant payments businesses have significantly expanded their lending offerings. A calibrated MDR framework for large merchants could rebalance these incentives by making payments commercially sustainable again. That would attract fresh investment, encourage new entrants, and foster competition in a market where regulatory caps alone have failed to dilute concentration.

Sarthak Gupta
Mumbai

QUICKLY.

SBI MF launches Magnum Ex-top 100 Long Short Fund



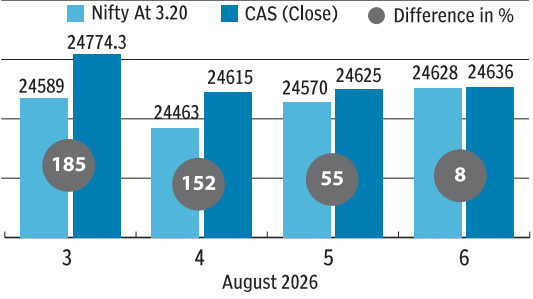
Mumbai: SBI Mutual Fund will launch its second investment strategy under the Specialised Investment Fund framework, Magnum Equity Ex-Top 100 Long Short Fund. The open-ended fund will invest in equity and equity-related instruments, including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments, of stocks other than large caps. The NFO will open on August 7. Debasish Mishra, MD & CEO, SBI Funds Management, said with its emphasis beyond the top 100 companies and its systematic long-short construct, the fund broadens product suite in a way that supports the diverse and increasingly sophisticated expectations of investors. **OUR BUREAU**

Closing price gap narrows for Nifty as markets adapt to CAS

IMPACT COST. Auction session expected to improve price discovery, may slightly reduce arbitrage opportunities

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

How it is moving



After the initial euphoria, the difference between the Closing Auction Session (CAS)-driven closing and the general market closing of the Nifty is slowly narrowing as markets adjust to the new system.

The difference between the Nifty's closing price pre-and post-CAS on Thursday was only 8 points.

The Nifty closed at 24,628 points at 3.15 pm, while post-CAS it settled at 24,636 points.

Similarly, on Wednesday, the Nifty closed at 24,570 at 3.15 pm and 24,625 post-CAS, posting a difference of 55 points.

On August 4 and August 3,

the difference was 155 and 184 points, respectively.

CLOSING MECHANISM

Exchanges implemented CAS on Monday, and the initial variation in index values and stock closing prices had stoked market concern. Instead of looking at trades

over the last 30 minutes, CAS collects all buy and sell orders at the end of the day into a single pool and determines a single price at which the maximum number of shares can be traded. This becomes the closing price.

Most global markets, including the New York Stock

Exchange and the London Stock Exchange, already use this method to determine the closing price of stocks.

The closing price under CAS reflects where buyers and sellers actually agree to trade, making it harder to influence prices with last-minute trades. Since large orders can be executed more efficiently, it reduces tracking error for index funds and ETFs.

Shweta Rajani, Head - Mutual fund, Anand Rath Wealth, said CAS is expected to make end-of-day prices more transparent and reduce sharp price movements near the market close.

Under the earlier system, the final 30 minutes of trading, especially on expiry and index rebalancing days, often saw wider price movements,

creating additional opportunities for arbitrage funds to capture spreads between the cash and futures markets.

As the new mechanism becomes more established, opportunities arising from end-of-day price movements may become less frequent, although fund managers are expected to adapt by identifying opportunities at other points during the trading day, she said.

Gibin John, Senior Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments, said the gains in the indices are largely due to wider cash-futures spreads and higher volatility.

In fact, CAS is expected to improve price discovery and may slightly reduce arbitrage opportunities over time, he said.

SEBI mulls multi-lingual reach out, Jagrook initiatives

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Tuhin Kanta Pandey, Chairman, SEBI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) plans to launch an AI-enabled multi-lingual investor awareness campaign through WhatsApp and other digital platforms, roll out a nationwide financial literacy initiative under Project Jagrook, and simplify nomination norms for demat accounts and mutual fund folios in FY27 as part of a broader push to simplify regulations, deepen capital markets and reduce compliance burden.

The roadmap, outlined in the regulator's annual report for the financial year 2025-26, also includes a single-window clearance mechanism for intermediaries associated with multiple market infrastructure institutions (MIIs), modernising intermediary interfaces through the proposed SEBI Setu portal, strengthening commodity markets and expanding technology-led investor protection initiatives.

"We will continue to focus on identifying and removing regulatory redundancies, simplifying procedural requirements and leveraging technology to ease the compliance burden," SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said in his statement.

"During 2025-26, we introduced a series of reforms, yet our vision for the future is even more ambitious. As the Indian securities market continues to evolve in scale and complexity, SEBI remains committed to fostering a proactive, technology-driven regulatory landscape centred on ease of doing business, market deepening and preserving market integrity," he said.

ROADMAP AHEAD

The regulator plans a comprehensive review of the

Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements (LODR) Regulations, the Depositories and Participants Regulations and the Portfolio Managers Regulations to streamline provisions, remove ambiguities and simplify regulatory language.

It also plans to introduce a fast-track mechanism for processing private placement memorandums filed by AIFs, leveraging the sophistication of investors and merchant bankers' due diligence.

"We will continue our focus on deepening the cash equities market to spur capital formation. The Securities Lending and Borrowing scheme needs revamping to improve price discovery and facilitate interlinkage between the cash and derivatives segments. We will continue our agenda to strengthen India's commodity markets — both agri and non-agri," Pandey said.

Technology will remain central to SEBI's regulatory agenda, it said.

The regulator also plans to prepare the market for quantum-era cybersecurity risks and develop long-term technology roadmaps for MIIs.

SEBI will be rolling out Project Jagrook, a nationwide investor awareness programme involving exchanges, depositories, AMFI and the National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM). It will also revamp the SEBI investor website with improved UI/UX and advanced search capabilities.

Shiprocket sets IPO price at ₹92-97, issue opens on Aug 12

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

E-commerce logistics firm Shiprocket Ltd will launch its initial public offering on August 12, with bidding closing on August 14. It has fixed a price band of ₹92 to ₹97 per share. The minimum bid lot is 154 shares.

The total offer size is ₹1,617.48 crore. This comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹885.50 crore and an OFS of up to ₹731.98 crore. The shares will be listed on the BSE and the NSE.

USE OF FUNDS

Proceeds from the fresh issue will be deployed across

four areas — marketing investments for the company's core and emerging businesses; technology infrastructure development; repayment or prepayment of existing borrowings, including accrued interest and funding unidentified acquisitions for inorganic growth; and general corporate purposes.

At least 75 per cent of the net offer is reserved for qualified institutional buyers while non-institutional bidders may access up to 15 per cent and retail investors up to 10 per cent. Employees are offered a reservation of up to ₹1 crore, with a potential discount of up to ₹9 a share on the offer price.

MV Electrosystems jumps 47% over IPO price, Juniper Green ends Day 1 with 15% gains

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

MV Electrosystems and Juniper Green Energy made a strong debut on the exchanges on Thursday, listing at premiums over their respective IPO prices.

Among them, MV Electrosystems emerged as the stronger performer, rising 47 per cent to end at its upper circuit.

MV Electrosystems listed at ₹519 on the BSE, a premium of 22 per cent over its IPO price of ₹425 and closed at ₹622.75 (46.5 per cent). On the NSE, the stock debuted at ₹520 and closed



BRIGHT START. Krishnan Iyer (second from left), Head-Issuer Relationships, NSE, with officials of Juniper Green Energy at the listing ceremony of the shares on Thursday

at ₹624 (+46.8 per cent).

Shivani Nyati, Head of Wealth at Swastika Investment Ltd, said MV Electrosystems delivered a weak FY26 performance as revenue declined around 21 per cent y-o-y and posted a loss

of ₹12.6 crore. She said the investment story now depends on improving execution and returning to profits.

JUNIPER GREEN

Juniper Green Energy listed at ₹245 on the NSE, a

premium of around 9 per cent over its IPO price of ₹225, and closed with 15 per cent gains at ₹259.71. On the BSE, the stock debuted at ₹242 and closed at ₹259.60.

Nyati said the company has strong growth potential, backed by a 7.9 GW capacity pipeline, long-term PPAs and a planned ₹1,411 crore debt reduction. However, she said the IPO is richly valued while current profitability remains modest.

The IPO of MV Electrosystems, entirely a fresh issue, was subscribed 188.85 times. Juniper Green Energy's ₹1,800-crore IPO, also entirely a fresh issue, was subscribed 7.97 times.

Milky Mist IPO: Price band fixed at ₹133-140; issue opens on Aug 11

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Milky Mist Dairy Food Ltd will open its initial public offering on Tuesday, August 11, in the price band of ₹133 to ₹140 per share.

The issue closes on August 13, with anchor investor bidding scheduled for Monday, August 10.

The total offer size aggregates up to ₹1,553

crore, comprising a fresh issue of up to ₹1,428 crore and an OFS of up to ₹125 crore.

The OFS includes shares worth ₹75 crore by Sathishkumar T and ₹50 crore by Anitha S.

Investors can bid for a minimum lot of 107 shares. Eligible employees bidding under the employee reservation portion will receive a discount of ₹13 per share.

Before the IPO, the



company completed a pre-IPO placement aggregating ₹357 crore.

ISSUE STRUCTURE

The offer follows the

book-building process with up to 50 per cent reserved for qualified institutional buyers, not less than 15 per cent for non-institutional bidders, and

not less than 35 per cent for retail individual bidders. Up to 60 per cent of the QIB portion may be allocated to anchor investors on a discretionary basis.

The equity shares are proposed to be listed on both the BSE and the NSE.

JM Financial Ltd, Axis Capital Ltd and IIFL Capital Services Limited are the book-running lead managers for the issue.

Revenue growth will be bigger driver of earnings

bl.interview

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai



The topsy-turvy ride of equity markets has been giving sleepless night to investors. MF investors have turned anxious with their SIPs delivering negative returns in the last two-three years.

A Balasubramanian, MD and CEO, and Harish Krishnan, CIO-Equity, Aditya Birla Sun Life Asset Management Company, spoke on various topics that impact the market.

Edited excerpts:

Will the rise in crude oil pose a challenge for India?

Balasubramanian: India has handled recent oil price volatility better than many expected because it has diversified crude sourcing, reducing supply-side risks. Policy-makers have also managed demand effectively, while rapid growth in renewable energy is lowering the country's long-term dependence on imported fossil fuels.

As long as crude prices remain below \$100 a barrel, the economy should be able to absorb higher prices.

Krishnan: India's energy intensity has steadily declined as the services sector has expanded, making the economy less vulnerable to energy price

Start-ups and emerging sectors, such as biofuels and renewable energy, are creating new employment and investment opportunities

A BALASUBRAMANIAN
MD and CEO,
Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC

shocks. The next priority is strengthening energy security by expanding transmission infrastructure for renewables and increasing domestic manufacturing across the clean energy value chain. Coal gasification also offers an opportunity to reduce dependence on imported fuels.

Will lay-offs and slower hiring in sectors, such as IT, derail consumption growth?

Krishnan: Slower hiring in IT should not be mistaken for weakness across the broader economy. Employment and incomes are expanding

across a wider range of service professions, while the creator economy and other new industries are generating fresh opportunities.

Consumption is also being supported by GST rate reductions, improving credit growth, continued state government spending and the prospect of higher government salaries over the next 18 to 24 months.

Balasubramanian: Start-ups and emerging sectors such as biofuels and renewable energy are creating new employment and investment opportunities.

As the economy diversifies, these industries are generating fresh demand for equipment, infrastructure and consumer spending.

Will corporate earnings slowdown due to the rise in input cost?

Krishnan: Margins may face some pressure, but revenue growth will be the bigger driver of earnings.

Corporate India's biggest challenge in recent years has been weak nominal GDP growth, which limited top-line expansion.

As nominal GDP improves, stronger revenue growth should more than offset modest pressure on margins.

For investors, stronger revenue growth matters more than small changes



India's energy intensity has steadily declined as the services sector has expanded, making the economy less vulnerable to energy price shocks

HARISH KRISHNAN
CIO-Equity,
Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC

in margins because it also drives fresh capital expenditure. That trend is already visible, with more companies announcing large investment plans.

Will automobile sales slow after benefits of the GST rate cuts fade?

Krishnan: Passenger vehicles benefited significantly from the GST reduction, but recent sales suggest demand has remained resilient even as the tax-related boost has faded.

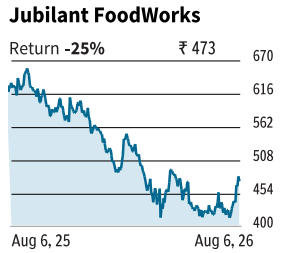
Balasubramanian: Consumption today is supported by a much broader base than before. As new industries and occupa-

tions emerge, demand is becoming more diversified and resilient.

TODAY'S PICK.

Jubilant FoodWorks (₹473.75): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Jubilant FoodWorks has been rallying over the past two weeks. On Monday, it broke out of a resistance at ₹456; it hit a four-month high of ₹495.10 on Wednesday and has now moderated to ₹473.75.

The rally began on the back of the support at ₹410.

Overall, the price action suggests that the stock has potentially turned the outlook positive, and a further rally is on the cards.

We expect it to appreciate to ₹600 before the end of this year. Therefore, traders can go long now at ₹473 and buy more

shares if the price drops to ₹460. Place initial stop-loss at ₹430. When the stock hits ₹550, revise the stop-loss to ₹525. On a rally to ₹575, raise the stop-loss to ₹550. Book profits at ₹600.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24738 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24650	24500	24750	25000	Buy if the contract breaks out of 24750; place stop-loss at 24650.

₹737 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
733	730	742	756	Buy the stock if it rallies above 742; place stop-loss at 735.

₹1165 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1158	1140	1190	1220	The stock could see a rally; buy now with a stop-loss at 1155.

₹285 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
284	280	292	295	The stock might see an upswing; buy with stop-loss at 280.

₹237 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
236	232	244	248	Go short as the price is likely to fall; place stop-loss at 242.

₹1325 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1300	1275	1350	1400	Buy if the price moderates to 1300; keep stop-loss at 1270.

₹1084 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1065	1050	1100	1150	Go long when the price slips to 1065; stop-loss can be 1040.

₹2370 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2350	2300	2430	2500	The scrip is likely to rebound; buy at 2350 with stop-loss at 2300.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers ▲ 11.35 pts.					
	Close(%)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Reliance Ind	1325.00	66.43	20.34	7.94	
State Bank	1085.00	27.10	11.56	3.98	
ICICI Bank	1457.50	11.58	17.50	9.26	
Eternal Ltd.	316.25	9.32	704.83	2.03	
Titan	4998.00	7.72	87.45	1.83	
Bharat Elec	399.20	7.20	47.47	1.27	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1141.00	5.69	23.72	1.42	
Sun Pharma	1951.00	2.55	38.63	1.83	
NestleIndia	1535.00	2.35	77.67	0.98	
Cipla	1477.00	2.24	35.56	0.74	
Apollo Hosp	8974.50	1.45	64.44	0.82	
Axis Bank	1256.00	1.32	13.98	3.20	
L&T	4061.80	1.23	28.48	4.22	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	263.10	0.82	84.07	0.77	
Coal India	415.60	0.05	8.24	0.88	
Bajaj Finserv	2086.00	0.00	16.18	1.07	
Grossm Ind	3220.00	-0.33	21.27	1.08	
Axis Capital	2755.00	-0.49	54.63	1.11	
Wipro	186.12	-0.51	13.88	0.45	
Eicher Motors	7967.50	-0.57	37.89	0.97	
HDFC Life	542.50	-0.59	59.27	0.52	
Dr Reddys Lab	1171.00	-0.67	30.70	0.63	
Adani Ports	401.00	-0.80	29.76	1.31	
TataConsumerProduct	10990.00	-0.90	65.69	0.63	
Hind Unilever	2079.50	-1.12	46.56	1.64	
Max Healthcare	1072.40	-1.24	72.36	0.71	
Adani Enter	3026.00	-1.51	52.40	0.77	
Trent Ltd.	3107.10	-1.59	96.26	0.92	
SBI Life	1861.50	-1.81	71.80	0.74	
Tata Motors PV	345.35	-2.03	42.93	1.64	
ONGC	237.80	-2.04	6.68	0.82	
ITC	285.90	-2.21	17.75	2.44	
HDFC Bank	734.30	-2.34	13.71	9.97	
Tech Mahindra	1632.20	-2.47	30.98	0.92	
UltraTech Cement	12075.00	-2.97	43.51	1.27	
Maruti Suzuki	14080.00	-3.14	30.86	1.63	
HCL Tech	1335.00	-3.46	20.78	1.25	
IntGlobeavi	5318.50	-4.03	0.00	1.07	
Hindalco	1027.00	-4.11	17.23	1.33	
Bajaj Auto	11620.00	-4.36	28.11	1.14	
JSW Steel	1307.90	-4.53	11.42	1.09	
NTPC	345.00	-5.08	11.81	1.45	
Tata Steel	189.30	-6.67	20.98	1.39	

CM
Y
K

IT sector’s share of fresher hiring slumps to 24 per cent, says report

DISTINCT TRENDS. The IT occupation index rose 10% year-on-year while the IT industry index fell 6%

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

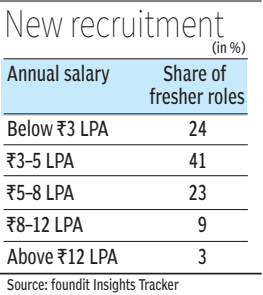
India’s technology hiring story is splitting into two distinct trends. While demand for technology professionals grew 10 per cent over the past year, the IT industry’s share of fresher hiring dropped sharply from 32 per cent to 24 per cent, according to the foundit Insights Tracker (fit) for July 2026.

The IT occupation index rose 10 per cent year-on-year while the IT industry index fell 6 per cent.

Technology roles are increasingly being filled outside technology companies — inside banks, manufacturers, healthcare firms and global capability centres (GCCs).

TECH WORK

Fresher hiring overall declined 2 per cent month-on-month and 10 per cent y-o-y. Across the market, the 7-10



year experience band was the only cohort to grow, up 2 per cent m-o-m and 11 per cent y-o-y.

“One in four entry-level IT jobs has disappeared over the past year, even as demand for tech work has continued to grow. That gap is a choice companies are making, not a market condition. Hiring experienced talent is faster, but it is also a smaller pool to compete for. The organisations that keep hiring graduates through a slow year are investing in future capability — they’re building tomorrow’s leadership pipeline rather than compet-



ing for an increasingly expensive experienced workforce a few years down the line,” said Tarun Sinha, CEO, foundit. AI-led roles account for 4 per cent of all fresher hiring, up from around 1 per cent in 2025.

AI adoption is creating a different mix of entry-level opportunities. Rather than hiring graduates primarily to build AI models, employers are increasingly recruiting talent to operate, validate and optimise AI systems. Operational AI roles now account for over half of entry-level AI hiring.

Roles that build AI systems — AI/ML engineers (28 per cent of AI hiring), data scientists (9 per cent) and

generative AI developers (7 per cent) — make up 44 per cent of entry-level AI jobs. Roles that operate, validate and direct those systems — data analysts (24 per cent), prompt engineers (12 per cent), AI operations (10 per cent) and AI QA & testing (5 per cent) — make up 51 per cent.

The shift towards specialised hiring is also reflected in fresher salaries.

Two-thirds of entry-level roles are paid below ₹5 lakh per annum, concentrated in sales, customer support, operations, retail and entry-level services.

DATA SCIENCE

At the other end, 12 per cent of fresher roles offer ₹8 lakh or more — and these cluster tightly in AI, data science, cybersecurity, semiconductor and product engineering. The pay data closes the loop on the year’s central trend: the entry door into technology has not shut, but it now

opens for candidates who arrive specialised rather than for generalists hired at volume.

Fresher hiring in 2026 remains heavily skewed toward lower salary bands, with 41 per cent of entry-level roles offering annual salaries between ₹3 lakh and ₹5 lakh, making it the largest hiring segment. Another 24 per cent of fresher jobs pay below ₹3 lakh per annum, meaning nearly two-thirds (65 per cent) of entry-level hiring is concentrated below the ₹5 lakh mark.

At the higher end, 23 per cent of roles offer ₹5-8 lakh, while only 9 per cent fall in the ₹8-12 lakh bracket and just 3 per cent offer salaries above ₹12 lakh per annum, underscoring that premium fresher packages remain limited to a small share of high-skill roles.

The report also noted that GCCs raised their share of fresher hiring from 8 per cent to 11 per cent, the largest gain of any employer type.

RBI issues comprehensive loan recovery rules to protect borrowers from harassment

Our Bureau
Mumbai



To ensure fair treatment of borrowers during the recovery process, the RBI has issued comprehensive instructions to lenders, including asking them to contact/visit a borrower/guarantor only between 8 am and 7 pm, and to avoid inappropriate occasions, such as bereavement in the family or medical emergencies, for making calls/visits.

As per the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks — Responsible Business Conduct) Fourth Amendment Directions, 2026, which come into effect from January 1, 2027, lenders, including banks and non-banking finance companies, have to ensure that their employees/recovery agents don’t use abusive language or use social media for posting video/audio recordings or personal

details of the borrower/guarantor.

Lenders need to put in place mitigants, including penalty provisions, to ensure that their employees/recovery agencies do not misuse customer information in any manner. They have to record the content/text of the calls made.

Further, lenders can restrict or turn off the functionality of a mobile device — a mobile phone, tablet or laptop — only if the bank finances the device through a

loan. The RBI said lenders have to put in place a policy on the collection/recovery of loan dues, including taking possession of a security by their own employee or a recovery agent.

The policy shall, *inter alia*, cover aspects related to trigger(s) for initiating the recovery process, graded actions as per an escalation matrix for loan recovery, and a code of conduct for employees and recovery agents.

FINANCIAL DISTRESS

The policy will also include aspects relating to recovery of loan dues in case of the borrower’s demise, a structured framework for handling cases involving financial distress, including documented pre-escalation engagement and guidance regarding available resolution options, etc.

The RBI said a bank shall document the time and number of calls made by its em-

ployee/recovery agent to the borrower/guarantor for recovery of loan dues.

Further, the bank shall ensure that recordings of the content/text of calls made by the employee/recovery agent to the borrower/guarantor, and by the borrower/guarantor to the telephone/mo-

bile number provided by the bank, are maintained.

A bank shall ensure that its recovery targets or the structure of incentives for its employees, or those covered under its contract with a recovery agency, do not induce the adoption of harsh recovery practices.

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)

The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 3rd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)

The Tata Power Company Limited invites tender from eligible vendors for the following tender packages (Two-part Bidding) in Mumbai.

(A) Three-Year Outline Agreement for Mobilization of Cable Fault Testing Van Services. **(Package Ref No: CC27AM006).**

(B) Procurement of Fault Passage Indicators (FPI) for Transmission Overhead Lines. **(Package Ref: CC27PRD009).**

Interested and eligible bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter before **1500 Hrs. of 17th August 2026, Monday.**

For downloading the Tender documents (Including the procedure for participation in the tender), please visit the Tender section on the website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum (if any), to the above tender will be informed on the website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

Ola Electric pivots to dealer-led retail after 5 years of own stores

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Ola Electric has outsourced its sales and service network to dealer partners across India, shifting to a dealership model after five years of operating company-owned stores.

The company said its in-house outlets had helped build awareness around electric vehicles, establish the Ola brand and create India’s largest electric two-wheeler customer base of over one million riders.

The move follows a month-long engagement with prospective dealers across the country. Ola Electric said it received a strong response, with dealers expressing confidence in the brand and the opportunity.

SIGNIFICANT SHIFT

“This is a big shift in how we go to market, and one that reflects where the EV industry in India is headed. We built our own stores first because trust in EVs had to be earned store by store, city by city. Now, as the category matures, our job is to bring EVs to every corner of the country, and dealer partners understand their local markets in ways no company-owned network can replicate at that scale,” said Bhavish Aggarwal, Chairman and Managing Director, Ola Electric.

Aggarwal added that the company’s own stores would continue to serve as experience centres, while dealer partners would help expand its reach into smaller towns and neighbourhoods.

For dealer partners, Ola Electric is offering access to a brand built over five years, a recurring service opportunity services from its installed base of more than one million electric two-wheelers, and a portfolio spanning scooters and motorcycles.

The company expects the dealership programme to achieve meaningful on-ground scale by Diwali 2026.

HSBC InvestDirect Financial Services (India) Limited

Registered office : 9-11 Floor, NESCO IT Park, Building No. 3, Western Express Highway, Goregaon (East), Mumbai - 400063 Toll Free No. 18002094477
E-mail: nbfchelpdesk@hsbc.co.in, CIN No. U67190MH1996PLC097473

STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER YEAR ENDED JUNE 30, 2026

(in INR lakh)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended			Year ended
		June 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Refer Note 5)	June 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)
1	Total income from operations	6,571.43	5,778.29	4,098.74	20,244.49
2	Net profit for the period (before tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,757.93	2,268.21	1,848.24	7,533.28
3	Net profit for the period before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,757.93	2,268.21	1,848.24	7,533.28
4	Net profit for the period after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,307.53	1,687.61	1,354.28	5,595.11
5	Total comprehensive income for the period (comprising profit / (loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax))	1,307.53	1,680.52	1,354.28	5,588.02
6	Paid up equity share capital	14,628.47	14,628.47	14,628.47	14,628.47
7	Reserves (excluding revaluation reserve)	31,493.62	30,186.08	25,952.34	30,186.08
8	Share Premium account	19,346.80	19,346.80	19,346.80	19,346.80
9	Net worth	65,423.09	64,127.15	59,892.31	64,127.15
10	Paid up debt capital/outstanding debt	2,25,739.34	2,27,334.46	1,33,284.72	2,27,334.46
11	Outstanding redeemable preference shares	-	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio	3.45	3.54	2.22	3.54
13	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) -				
	1. Basic:	0.89	1.15	0.93	3.82
	2. Diluted:	0.89	1.15	0.93	3.82
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-

Notes:

1 The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on August 05, 2026. The statutory auditors of the company have carried out limited review of the aforesaid results.

2 The above is an extract of the detailed format of unaudited financial results for the quarter ended June 2026, filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 52 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (SEBI LODR Regulations, 2015). The full format of the quarter ended June 2026 financial results are available on the websites of the National Stock Exchange i.e. www.nseindia.com and on the website of the Company i.e. www.hsbc.co.in/hifsl/.

3 For the other line items referred in regulation 52 (4) of the LODR Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the National Stock Exchange and can be accessed on www.nseindia.com. The same is also available on the website of the Company at www.hsbc.co.in/hifsl/.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors of **HSBC InvestDirect Financial Services (India) Limited**

Sd/-
Berlin Varghese
Managing Director
(DIN 10059070)

Place : Mumbai
Date : August 5, 2026

HSBC | InvestDirect

GUJARAT AMBUJA EXPORTS LIMITED
NURTURING BRANDS

Standalone Performance Graph for the Quarter Ended 30th June, 2026

Nurturing Brands Building Futures
At GAEL, we cultivate brands with care, innovation, and dedication

EPS 170% PAT 171% PBT 174%

STANDALONE FINANCIAL HIGHLIGHTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30th JUNE, 2026
(₹ in crores)

HIGHLIGHTS	30.06.2026	30.06.2025
Sales	1594.27	1291.23
EBITDA	271.13	126.90
Cash Profit Before Tax	268.68	121.47
Profit Before Tax	235.44	86.05
Profit After Tax	176.93	65.40
Cash Profit After Tax	210.17	100.82
EPS - in ₹ per share (FV ₹1/-)	3.86	1.43

Regd. Office : “AMBUJA TOWER”, Opp. Sindhu Bhavan, Sindhu Bhavan Road, Bodakdev, P.O. Thaltej, Ahmedabad - 380 054.
Ph. : +91 79 6155 6677, Fax : +91 79 6155 6678,
Email : info@ambujagroup.com Website : www.ambujagroup.com
CIN : L15140GJ1991PLC016151

Note : This is not a statutory advertisement. For detailed financial results, please refer our website www.ambujagroup.com

MEENAKSHI INDIA LIMITED
CIN : L74300TN1987PLC014678
Regd. Office 29 / 16 Whites Road, IV Floor, Royapettah, Chennai - 600014
Phone: 044-42636795. EMAIL ID: ho.accounts@milgroup.in, www.milgroup.in
Statement of Un-audited Financial Results for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026
(Rs. in Lakhs except per share data)

PART I

Sl.No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			
		30.06.2026 Unaudited	30.06.2025 Unaudited	31.03.2026 Audited - Refer Note 3	31.03.2026 Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	3,936	3,742	4,671	15,823
2	Net Profit for the period before Tax (before Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	763	334	786	1,570
3	Net Profit for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	763	334	786	1,553
4	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary items)	713	282	452	1,046
5	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after Tax for Discontinued Operations	-	-	-	-
6	Total Comprehensive income/(loss) for the period (comprising profit for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive income (after tax))	713	277	542	1,136
7	Equity Share Capital	1,125	1,125	1,125	1,125
8	Other Equity excluding Revaluation Reserve	-	-	-	11,940
9	Earnings Per Share (EPS) of Rs. 10 each	-	-	-	-
a	Continued Operations EPS	6.34	2.51	4.02	9.30
b	Dis-continued Operations EPS	-	-	-	-

1. The above unaudited financial results have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standard (referred to as "Ind AS") as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules as amended from time to time. These results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and thereafter approved by the Board of Directors at their Meeting held on August 5, 2026. The Statutory Auditors of the Company have carried out the limited review of the results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026.

2. In accordance with IND AS 108 - "Segment Reporting" the company has identified the following business segments: a) Apparel and Textiles; and b) Others

3. The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of the full financial year and the published unaudited year to date figures up to the end of the third quarter of that financial year.

4. Previous year/ periods' figures have been regrouped wherever appropriate to conform to current year/ periods' presentation.

5. The financial results are available on the website of BSE, CSE and the Company - www.milgroup.in

Place : Chennai
Date : 05.08.2026

For Meenakshi India Limited
Ashutosh Goenka, Managing Director
DIN: 00181026

adventz **ZUARI AGRO CHEMICALS**

ZUARI AGRO CHEMICALS LIMITED
CIN: L20121GA2009PLC006177
Registered Office: Jai Kisaan Bhawan, Zuarinagar, Goa - 403 726.
Tel: 0832 2592431 E-mail: shares@adventz.com / Investor.Relations@adventz.com Website: www.zuari.in

INFORMATION REGARDING 17th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING (‘VC’)/OTHER AUDIO VISUAL MEANS (‘OAVM’)

In compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (‘the Act’) read with the applicable rules made thereunder and General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020, 17/2020 dated 13th April, 2020, 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020, 09/2024 dated 19th September, 2024 and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, latest being General Circular 03/2025 dated 22nd September 2025 issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs(MCA) Government of India (collectively referred to as “MCA Circulars”) and the provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligation and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, Shareholders may please note that the 17th (Seventeenth) Annual General Meeting (“AGM”) of the Company will be held on **Wednesday, 16th September, 2026 at 3.30 P.M. (IST)** through Video Conferencing (‘VC’)/Other Audio Visual Means (‘OAVM’) (herein after referred to as “electronic mode”) to transact the business that will be set forth in the Notice of the AGM.

In compliance with the aforesaid MCA Circulars and SEBI Circulars, the electronic copies of the Notice convening the 17th (Seventeenth) Annual General Meeting (“AGM”) together with the Annual Report of the Company for the financial year 2025-26 will be sent, within the prescribed timelines, by e-mail to all the Members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company/Depository participants/RTA. The said Notice convening the 17th Annual General Meeting together with the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 will also be available on the Company’s website at http://www.zuari.in/investor/annual_reports and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com.

A letter providing the web-link for accessing the annual report for the financial year 2025-26 will be sent to those shareholders who have not registered their email address with the Company/Depositories.

Members are therefore requested to register their email addresses for receiving electronic copies of the Notice convening the 17th AGM along with the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 in the following manner:

1. **For shareholders holding shares in physical mode** – A duly filled and signed copy of request letter Form ISR-1 mentioning details such as Folio Number, Name of the Shareholder, Mobile Number and the e-mail address to be registered, together with a scanned copy of the share certificate (front and back), self-attested copy of PAN and self-attested copy of Aadhaar, may be sent by e-mail to the Company at shares@adventz.com or to the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (“RTA”) at Investor.helpdesk@in.mpmc.mufg.com. Members may download the prescribed Form ISR-1 from the Company’s website at <http://www.zuari.in/investor/kyc> compliance.

2. **For shareholders holding shares in Demat mode** – Shareholders are requested to contact their Depository Participant (“DP”) and register/update their e-mail address and bank account details in their demat account, in accordance with the procedure prescribed by the DP.

Pursuant to SEBI Master Circular No. HO/38/13/(4)2026-MIRSD-POD/II/4298/2026 dated 6th February, 2026, issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”), Members holding shares in physical form are requested to furnish/update their PAN, nomination details, contact details (postal address with PIN code and mobile number), bank account details, specimen signatures and such other documents/information as may be prescribed from time to time, in respect of their respective folios.

In case any of the aforesaid details/documents are not available in the records of the Company/Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (“RTA”), Members shall not be able to lodge any grievance or avail any service request from the RTA until the requisite KYC details/documents are furnished. Further, as per SEBI Requirements applicable since 1st April, 2024, all payments, including dividend, shall be made only through electronic mode to those Members who have furnished the prescribed KYC details.

The Company is providing the facility of remote e-voting (“remote e-voting”) to its Members to cast their votes on the resolutions that will be set forth in the Notice convening the 17th (Seventeenth) Annual General Meeting (“AGM”). The Company is also providing the facility of voting through the electronic voting system during the AGM (“e-voting”). The detailed procedure for remote e-voting/e-voting by Members holding shares in dematerialised mode, physical form and by Members whose e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company or the Depository Participants will be provided in the Notice convening the AGM.

For Zuari Agro Chemicals Limited
Sd/-
Asheeba Pereira
Company Secretary

Date : 6th August, 2026
Place : Zuarinagar, Goa

QUICKLY.

Gold near 7-week high on easing rate hike concerns



Gold climbed to a seven-week high on Thursday, extending gains into a fourth session, as hopes surrounding the re-opening of the Strait of Hormuz eased mounting fears around inflation and higher-for-longer interest rates. Spot gold was up 0.4 per cent at \$4,261.86 per ounce by 1125 GMT. US gold futures rose 0.4 per cent to \$4,321.40. Silver fell 0.6 per cent to \$61.69. Platinum was up 1 per cent to \$1,752.73 and palladium climbed 1.4 per cent to \$1,382.87 — with both metals up for a third consecutive session. REUTERS

Copper jumps to 6-month high on tight stocks



London: Copper prices hit their highest in six months as worries about tightening stocks outside the United States coincided with concerns about reduced supply of concentrates from the Democratic Republic of Congo. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange was 1.1 per cent higher at \$14,258 a tonne. COMEX copper futures hit a record high of \$6,723 per lb. Nickel was down 2 per cent at \$16,770, while zinc was up 1.8 per cent at \$3,795. Tin edged lower at \$56,675, while aluminium rose 0.5 per cent to \$3,258. Lead gained 0.4 per cent to \$1,893. REUTERS

Global sugar prices poised to rule lower this quarter

MIXED SIGNALS. Easing geopolitical tensions and stronger-than-expected supplies may drag prices, but El Nino and geopolitical tensions pose risks

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Global sugar prices topped 15 US cents a pound on the InterContinental Exchange, New York, this week as traders feared the market could face a deficit. However, a few analysts project a fall in global sugar prices during the current quarter and the next due to easing geopolitical tensions and stronger-than-expected supplies. On the other hand, the ongoing El Nino weather and renewed geopolitical tensions pose risks to production and supplies, they said. On Thursday, October sugar contracts in New York were quoted at 15.19 cents per pound (\$340/tonne). In London, white sugar ruled at \$482.60 a tonne for October delivery. Covrig Analytics pegged

the sugar deficit at 3 lakh tonnes, compared with its earlier projection of 1 lakh tonnes surplus. Another analytical firm, Green Pool Commodity Specialists, pegged the deficit at 3.3 million tonnes (mt) from an earlier estimate of 1.76 mt.

Q3 PRICE OUTLOOK Research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions, expects sugar prices to average 15.2 cents a pound, up from 14.6 cents in Q1 and 14.2 cents in Q2. “We are revising our 2026 average price forecast for front-month ICE-listed #11 raw sugar futures to 14.9 cents per lb, representing a year-on-year decline of 11.3 per cent,” it said. Prices found support in late Q1 and early Q2 from the US-Iran conflict and the consequent rise in global energy prices, reaching a year-to-date high of 15.9 cents a



MULTIPLE FACTORS AT PLAY. Prices found support in late Q1 and early Q2 from the US-Iran conflict and the consequent rise in global energy prices

pound on March 24, from which prices have since retreated by 8.8 per cent as of July 29, it said. ING Think, the economic and financial analysis wing of Dutch multinational finan-

cial services firm ING, said in its 2026 outlook that raw sugar prices will average 15.4 cents per pound this year, with the third quarter the weakest as it is the peak of the CS Brazil harvest.

NARROWING SURPLUS The US Department of Agriculture, in its “Sugar: Markets and Trade”, said global production is forecast lower by 1.2 million tonnes to 184.9 million in the 2026-27

season starting October, with lower production in Brazil, the European Union, the US and Thailand. BMI expects the global production surplus to narrow to 2.8 mt in the 2026-27 season, down from 7 mt in 2025-26. “Underpinning this is our forecast of a 2.3 per cent year-on-year decline in production to 182.4 mt, while consumption is expected to hold steady at 179.6 mt,” it said. ING Think said the sugar surplus this season is the highest since 2017-18. BMI expects Brazil’s output to reach 42 mt in the 2026-27 season, down 4.1 per cent year-on-year. “We expect Indian sugar production to reach 33 mt in the 2026/27 season, up 10 per cent year-on-year, though risks are weighted to the downside, the principal con-

cern being a strengthening El Nino,” it said. **THAILAND TO THE AID** “While our projections do point to a tighter market balance, and we note that relatively small downward revisions could tip the market into deficit, we caution against viewing the global sugar market as tight,” it said. The USDA has projected opening global stocks for the 2026-27 season at 43.5 mt, up three per cent year-on-year. BMI said Thailand’s 13.3 mt stocks will help overcome any impact of El Nino weather on global supplies. It said the risk to its price outlook was the US-Iran conflict, which could prolong till the fourth quarter. Higher crude oil prices could divert more sugar in Brazil towards ethanol.

ISMA, co-op sugar mills seek sops to offset early crushing losses

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) and the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories (NFCSF) have offered to advance the start of the 2026-27 crushing season by 10-15 days in October to improve domestic availability ahead of the festive season. The offer comes amid concerns over tightening sugar supplies and the possibility of limited imports. However, both industry bodies urged the Centre to provide financial support to offset the losses mills would incur due to an early start. In a joint letter to Union Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra on Thursday, ISMA

Director-General Deepak Ballani and NFCSF Managing Director Prakash Naiknavare said since the decision to begin crushing early had been taken in the national interest to augment supplies and help moderate prices during the festive season, the government should help mills absorb the associated operational and financial burden. **SUPPORT SOUGHT** The associations have sought compensation for sugar recovery losses arising from early crushing. They also proposed either an additional domestic sugar sale quota equivalent to the October production or a waiver of the CGST on domestic sugar sales. Referring to a meeting with government officials on

July 17, they said the industry had proposed advancing the start of the October-September sugar season by 10-15 days, subject to favourable agro-climatic conditions. This, they said, would ensure fresh sugar reaches the market well before the festive demand peaks, strengthening consumer confidence and ensuring smooth supplies. In a joint statement, ISMA and NFCSF maintained that India continued to have adequate sugar stocks to comfortably meet domestic consumption and that there is no cause for concern over availability. They said that the proposal to begin crushing early reflects the industry’s commitment to supporting the government’s efforts to maintain uninterrupted supplies and a bal-

Industry maintains that sugar stocks are adequate, says that the recent price rise is driven by sentiment rather than supply shortages

anced domestic market.

PRICE MOVEMENT The two associations argued that the recent rise in sugar prices did not reflect the underlying demand-supply situation. They said the pan-India average ex-mill sugar price during October 2025-June 2026 was around ₹39.50-40 per kg, below the average cost of production.

Even after the recent increase, average realisation up to July improved only to ₹40-40.50 per kg, still below the estimated production cost of ₹42 per kg. While the industry’s calculation of average realisations may be valid, the government’s concern is the recent upward movement in retail prices, driven largely by market sentiment rather than actual supply-demand fundamentals. Concerns over a potential shortage, reinforced by statistical estimates and the government’s July 24 order for physical verification of sugar stocks at mills, have fuelled speculation. Industry estimates suggest sugar stocks on October 1, 2026, could be only marginally higher than the month’s consumption, leaving little cushion for demand

during November. The associations also highlighted that member mills had already paid around ₹1.1 lakh crore to sugarcane farmers during the current season. “The recent price movement should, therefore, be viewed in its proper context and not as an indication of any supply constraint,” they said. They added that advancing the crushing season would have significant operational and financial implications. Early crushing typically results in lower cane maturity, reducing sugar recovery and cane yields, thereby affecting mills’ operational efficiency and financial viability. Meanwhile, the Centre has stepped up efforts to curb speculative trading. On July 28, it capped sugar

stocks held by dealers at 400 tonnes until November 30, directed traders to liquidate excess stocks by August 1, and mandated that sugar be sold within 30 days of receipt. These measures are aimed at improving market supplies and containing price volatility.

SOLITAIRE PRICE INDEX

7th August, 2026

4,558 *

0.89% ↑
Over last Month

0.02% ↑
Over last Year

Nationwide Standard & Transparent Pricing since 2006.
Released on the 1st of every month.
*This is an average of Divine Solitaire Price List

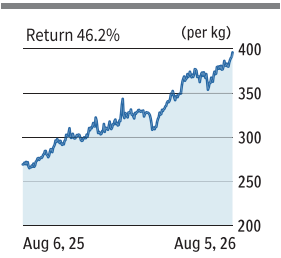
Zinc: Book profits at the current level of ₹393

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Zinc futures (₹393/kg) have been rallying since the final week of June after finding support at ₹350. Although the uptrend is valid, bulls are likely to face a challenge.

COMMODITY CALL.

The August futures broke out of the barrier at ₹380 last week and have been steadily moving up. Currently trading at ₹393, there are no signs of a reversal or weakness in price action. However, there is a trendline resistance at ₹395, which could trigger a corrective decline if not a bearish trend reversal. The price could dip to the ₹382-384 range before bouncing back again. If the contract extends the decline beyond ₹382 and breaches the subsequent



support at ₹380, the near-term outlook could turn weak. However, given the current strength in uptrend, a break below the support at ₹380 is unlikely. We expect zinc futures to drop to ₹382-384 and then rally to ₹400.

TRADE STRATEGY Last week, we suggested buying the August futures at ₹379 with a stop-loss at ₹366. Since there is a resistance ahead and there is a chance for a decline, book profits at the current level of ₹393. Fresh longs can be initiated once the contract steadies after a decline.

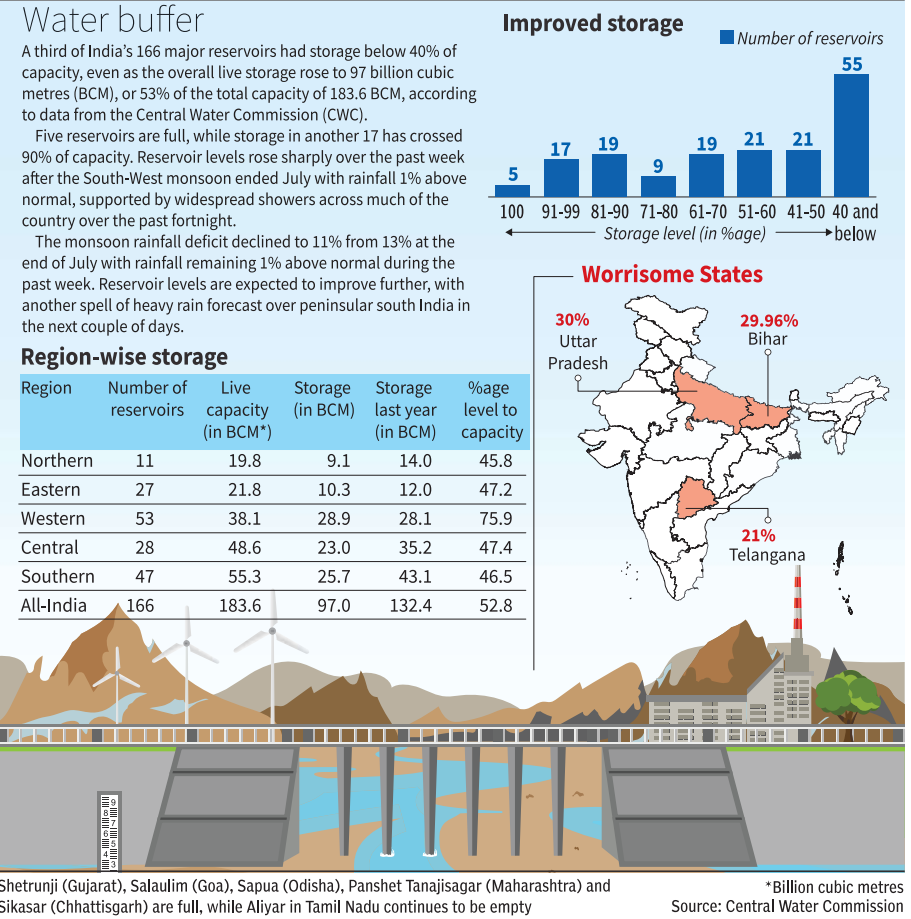
Kerala braces for renewed monsoon fury as IMD warns of heavy downpour

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala is set for another spell of intense monsoon weather, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) warning of heavy to very heavy rain over the State, as well as over coastal Karnataka and south interior Karnataka during the next two to three days. Heavy rain is forecast over Lakshadweep, north interior Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Karaikal on Friday; Kerala and south interior Karnataka on Saturday; and coastal Karnataka through Saturday and Sunday. Adding to the weather threat, strong surface winds are expected to lash coastal Karnataka, Kerala, Mahe, Lakshadweep, Rayalaseema and Telangana

over the next two days. North and south interior Karnataka could experience gusty conditions for up to three days. The renewed spell of wet weather is being shaped by an unusual interaction between the monsoon and a cluster of tropical systems over the West Pacific. Although Typhoon Dolphin and Tropical Storm Kujira have weakened, they have been succeeded by Storm Chan-Hom. Together, these systems continue to draw a substantial share of monsoon moisture eastward. **TRACK OF 'LOW'** A large part of the monsoon flow is currently being pulled towards these Pacific systems across the Bay of Bengal, while another branch is feeding moisture into North-East and East India through the

Myanmar-Bangladesh corridor. The evolving pattern could trigger the formation of a fresh low-pressure area over the Bay, helping re-anchor monsoon currents and sustain rainfall. Two upper-air cyclonic circulations are already in place — one over the north-west Bay and adjoining north Odisha-Gangetic West Bengal, and another over south-west Bengal and the adjoining Bangladesh. The eventual track of any low-pressure area that forms will determine how rainfall is distributed across East and North-East India. **N-W, CENTRAL INDIA** Beyond the southern part of the country, the IMD expects isolated heavy rainfall to continue across parts of North-West, Central, East and North-East India through much of the week.



Monsoon revival eases Telangana’s kharif worries, State sticks to crop diversification

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

Copious rainfall over the past week across several parts of Telangana has revived hopes for the kharif season. Until a fortnight ago, 23 of the State’s 33 districts were in the rainfall-deficit category, prompting the government to draw up a comprehensive action plan to promote pulses and millets as alternatives to paddy. A few days ago, Agriculture Minister Tummalala Nageswara Rao, citing the weather forecasts, said that the adverse impact of El Nino was likely to persist through August and advised farmers against taking up paddy cultivation. He directed the officials to keep adequate stocks of alternative crop seeds ready to support the farmers.

The Minister also warned that the El Nino impact could extend into the rabi season. **POSITIVE OUTLOOK** However, widespread rain over the past few days have significantly improved the outlook. “We are better off than we were last week. Reports suggest that farmers in several districts are now in a safer position,” Jaipal, a farmer from Mahabubabad district, told *businessline*. Despite the improvement, the State government remains cautious and continues to discourage paddy cultivation. It estimates that the total kharif sowing area could decline by 20-25 per cent from last year’s level. **MILLETS, PULSES** “The fact that many farmers had to undertake a second

sowing reflects how precarious the situation remains. We are advising farmers, including those with borewell irrigation, to avoid paddy this season,” a government source said. “These late rains are certainly beneficial, particularly for paddy farmers,” said Prabhakar Vuppala, a farmer from Nizamabad. Data available up to July 29 show paddy acreage at about 8.28 lakh hectares, down from 8.9 lakh hectares a year ago. Maize sowing also declined to 1.9 lakh hectares from 2.19 lakh hectares last year. In contrast, redgram acreage edged up to 1.79 lakh hectares from 1.75 lakh hectares, while cotton registered a sharp increase to 18.62 lakh hectares from 17.4 lakh hectares in the corresponding period last year.

Crude oil rises as traders eye Iran-Oman deal

Bloomberg

Crude oil rose in a choppy session as traders waited for a final Iran-Oman deal to partially reopen the Strait of Hormuz, with the US position still unclear. Brent climbed near \$81 a barrel, after swinging between small gains and losses. Iran said an agreement on proposed shipping lanes was in the final stages. Prices are still holding most of this week’s slump after Iran and the US indicated a resolution was close for shipping through the crucial energy chokepoint. But Tehran has insisted that Washington is not part of the agreement with Oman and hinted that normalisation of the Strait will depend on the lifting of an US blockade on Iranian ports.

Residue-free cumin spices up Rajasthan’s farm income

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

A Department of Biotechnology (DBT)-led initiative in western Rajasthan has demonstrated that residue-free cumin production is feasible through the adoption of integrated pest management (IPM) protocols and good agriculture practices (GAP). Participating farmers’ realisations are higher by 25 per cent over the market price. Production of ‘IPM cumin’, which was 35,000 tonnes, has the potential to increase to 1 lakh tonnes, stakeholders said. The DBT-funded initiative, The Biotech-KISAN Hub for the Western Dry Region, came up with an integrated approach to cumin farming and value chain development, that was implemented by the South Asia Biotechnology Centre (SABC), Jodhpur, and ICAR-National Re-

search Centre on Seed Spices (NRCSS), Ajmer. The hub generated modules and promoted a package of practices developed by conducting field demonstrations, training programmes and distributing inputs and plant protection products and formulations in the key cumin growing districts of western Rajasthan during 2019-24 and also ensured buyback arrangements with corporates and exporters through farmer producer organisations in the sector. **SHOWING THE WAY** On average, IPM cumin fetched a 24 per cent premium over the market price for demonstration farmers, while reducing the cost of procurement by 25-35 per cent per acre through effective management of fungal disease and insect pests, said Bhagirath Choudhary, Founder Director, SABC. “Rajasthan’s success in IPM-based cumin cultivation marks a defining milestone in India’s journey towards sustainable, residue-free agriculture. Just as Maharashtra transformed grape cultivation through Integrated Pest Management (IPM), Rajasthan is now demonstrating how science-led, location-specific IPM protocols can shift farmers from chemical-intensive production to high-value, pesticide residue-free cumin that meets stringent international standards,” Choudhary said. Vinay Bharadwaj, Director, ICAR-National Research Centre on Seed Spices (NRCSS), Ajmer, said the bio formulations used in the IPM are now proven and expansion of this requires funding. Stakeholders such as corporates, industry, the Spices Board and research agencies should come together and

fund such an initiative. Krishna Kant, scientist at NRCSS, said now farmers are getting aware of the biological formulations used in IPM practices. Besides, the financial incentive of ₹5,000 per quintal provided by Gujarat over the market price for residue-free cumin is also attracting farmers’ interest. Hanif Khan of Barmer-based Janta Global, which sources IPM cumin from farmers directly for large companies and exporters, said growers are becoming aware of the advantages of chemical free farming as it reduces the cost of cultivation, besides fetching them more than the market price. Moreover, farmers growing IPM cumin need not go in search of buyers as they themselves are landing at the doorsteps of such farmers, considering the growing demand for residue free products in the Europe and the US, he said.

QUICKLY.

Tarun Tejpal sentenced to 10 years in rape case

Panaji: Journalist Tarun Tejpal was convicted for rape and sentenced to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment by the Bombay High Court on Thursday in a 2013 case that he was acquitted in at the trial court five years ago. The High Court termed the trial court's 2021 verdict as "perverse", noting that it fell for the notion that a sexual assault complainant must be a "perfect victim" and conduct herself in a certain way to appear credible. The 62-year-old journalist claimed that he was a political victim and would approach the Supreme Court to challenge his conviction. [PTI](#)

Swan Defence bags ₹750-cr export orders

Ahmedabad: Swan Defence and Heavy Industries (SDHI) has secured an export contract worth up to ₹750 crore from the Denmark-based towage operator Svitzer A/S to build four advanced TRANverse 3200 harbour tugs, marking the Indian shipbuilder's fourth consecutive overseas order. The vessels will be built at SDHI's shipyard in Pipavav, Gujarat, with deliveries scheduled to commence in early 2028, the company said on Thursday. [OUR BUREAU](#)

Cabinet approves ₹23,731-crore GOBARdhan bioenergy scheme

GROWTH CATALYST. Scheme aims to boost rural bioeconomy by fixing key bottlenecks

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Cabinet on Thursday approved GOBARdhan, or the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme, with a total outlay of ₹23,731 crore, or roughly \$2.5 billion. The scheme aims to address long-standing bottlenecks such as assured offtake, stable pricing, evacuation infrastructure and efficient feedstock aggregation.

The scheme intends to increase domestic Compressed Biogas (CBG) production nearly ten-fold, mobilise large-scale private investment and create a vibrant circular bio-economy across the country.

"GOBARdhan marks a defining moment in India's clean energy journey. It will transform the country's abundant agricultural residue, cattle dung, press mud, municipal organic waste and other biomass resources into clean fuel, organic manure, rural income and national economic value," the government said.

FUTURE FUEL

The scheme, which will be implemented from FY27 to



ENERGY DRIVE. The scheme intends to increase domestic compressed biogas production nearly ten-fold and mobilise largescale private investment

FY36, will establish CBG as a major pillar of India's future energy mix through assured demand, remunerative and stable pricing, capital assistance, pipeline infrastructure, credit support and technology development, it added.

The government is focusing on six growth engines under the GOBARdhan scheme — assured off-take, stable pricing, capital assistance, developing pipeline infrastructure, credit guarantee and ecosystem challenge fund.

CRITICAL GAPS

Welcoming the initiative, Sanjay Ganjoo, Director General, Indian Federation of Green Energy, told *busi-*

nessline: "India generates nearly 500 million tonnes of agricultural residue annually, much of which is still burned in the fields, contributing to severe air pollution. With only about 216 CBG plants commissioned against the ambitious CBG blending targets, project viability has been constrained by inadequate synchronisation between CBG production and city gas distribution networks."

By supporting both production and distribution infrastructure, the government has addressed the sector's most critical challenges. Assured offtake and pipeline connectivity will improve project bankability, enhance investor confidence

and provide lenders with the long-term revenue visibility required to finance projects, he noted.

"Beyond clean energy, every CBG plant will stimulate local economic activity through feedstock collection, transportation, plant operations and organic manure management, generating sustainable employment and additional income for rural communities," Ganjoo emphasised.

Indian Biogas Association President AR Shukla also welcomed the latest policy push, adding that the sector has long argued that biogas needed three things — a remunerative price, assured offtake and capital support, which this scheme delivers.

Moving from roughly 300 operating plants towards 5,000 will create lakhs of rural jobs, he added.

Varun Karad, CEO of Renergy Dynamics, pointed out that the proposed credit guarantee and capital support mechanisms under the scheme should significantly improve project bankability and attract greater participation from developers, lenders, infrastructure investors and climate-focused funds.

Daily rooftop solar installations under PM Surya Ghar cross 16,300

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Minister for New & Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said on Thursday that residential rooftop solar power installations have risen from just 5,000 per day in October last year to more than 16,300 daily under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojna (PMSG: MBY).

Speaking at the CII International Energy Conference & Exhibition, he noted that the cumulative rooftop solar generation capacity, which includes government buildings, had reached 14 gigawatts (GW).

"The scheme has expanded to benefit 50 lakh households. The pace of installations has accelerated more than three-fold, from around 5,000 installations per day in October 2025 to over 16,000 per day in July 2026," Joshi said.

More than 12 lakh households had earned around ₹421 crore by selling surplus electricity, he added.

The scheme has helped create a nationwide rooftop solar ecosystem while supporting domestic renewable energy manufacturing. India is also approaching the landmark of 300 GW of installed non-fossil fuel power capacity and remains firmly on



Minister for New & Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi [PTI](#)

course to achieve its target of 500 GW by 2030, he added.

POLICY SUPPORT

The Minister highlighted several policy and regulatory initiatives by the government to strengthen the renewable energy ecosystem and to support industry growth.

These include the PLI Scheme for High Efficiency Solar PV Modules, the Green Energy Corridor programme, the reduction of GST on renewable energy devices and components, the extension of Basic Customs Duty exemptions on capital goods for lithium-ion cell manufacturing for Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS), and the launch of the Renewable Energy Equipment Import Monitoring System.

KEY PILLAR

Highlighting the critical role

of manufacturing in the energy transition, Minister of Steel and Heavy Industries HD Kumaraswamy, said, "As India accelerates its clean energy transition, energy security is no longer defined solely by access to resources. It is shaped by our ability to manufacture, innovate and build resilient domestic supply chains for the technologies of the future."

The ₹18,100-crore Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme for Advanced Chemistry Cell (ACC) batteries is supporting domestic battery manufacturing capacity and reducing import dependence, while the PM E-DRIVE Scheme is accelerating the growth of a robust clean mobility ecosystem and reinforcing India's ambition to emerge as a global hub for clean energy technologies, the Minister added.

BHUTAN'S PLANS

Bhutan's Minister of Energy and Natural Resources Lyonpo Gem Tshering said, "Our vision is to expand the country's power generation capacity to 25 GW by 2040 through the addition of 15 GW of hydropower and 5 GW of solar energy. This is driven by rising domestic energy demand and the need to ensure a reliable and sustainable electricity supply."

Tamil Nadu Agriculture Budget earmarks ₹58,374 crore for farming and allied sectors

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Agriculture Budget has earmarked ₹58,374 crore for agriculture and allied sectors in the Revised Budget Estimates (RBE) for 2026-27. The 2025-26 Agriculture Budget earmarked ₹45,661 crore.

Of the total allocation, capital expenditure stands at ₹8,689 crore, while revenue expenditure accounts for ₹49,685 crore. The Rural Development and Panchayat Raj department received the single-largest allocation of ₹18,103 crore.

The State has set a food-grain production target of 131 lakh tonnes in five years, to ensure food security. During 2026-27, the State plans to produce 125 lakh tonnes.

Targets have been set to increase the production of nutritious pulses, vegetables and fruits to achieve self-sufficiency and nutritional security via various schemes.



COTTON MISSION

The Cotton Renaissance Mission will be implemented on 73,360 acres at a total outlay of ₹27.21 crore from Union and State government funds, benefiting 40,000 farmers. Providing a thrust to organic farming, the Budget proposes an incentive of ₹4,000 per acre to farmers. This will cover 20,000 acres, for which ₹8 crore will be allocated. In addition, ₹9 crore will be allocated from Union and State government funds during 2026-27 to form Organic Farming Clusters covering

7,500 acres by mobilising farmers under the Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY) Scheme.

The Budget also proposed to form New Natural Farming Clusters, covering 3,125 acres, besides continuing with the second-year activities on 7,500 acres to produce safe and chemical-free food by improving soil health under the National Mission on Natural Farming.

UZHAVAR AI SCHEME

For ensuring quality of organic produce, certified under the National Programme for Organic Production, a 100 per cent subsidy will be extended for undertaking Pesticide Residue Analysis. The State has set aside ₹25 lakh for this.

The government has come up with an *Uzhavar* Artificial Intelligence Scheme to provide farmers with real-time information on soil health and crop cultivation. For the current fiscal, ₹2 crore has been allocated.

A scheme to enhance maize (corn) production will be implemented during 2026-27 on an outlay of ₹36 crore from Union and State government funds.

The State plans to increase the area under pulses, including black matpe, red gram, green gram and cowpea from 15.19 lakh acres to 24.70 lakh acres, and production from 3.88 lakh tonnes to 7.72 lakh tonnes.

The area under oilseeds such as groundnut, sesame, sunflower and castor will be increased from 9.26 lakh acres to 14.89 lakh acres and production from 8.77 lakh tonnes to 16.14 lakh tonnes.

In the 2026-27 fiscal, a Millet Mission will be implemented on a total outlay of ₹63.81 crore from Union and State government funds.

The Tamil Nadu Minor Millet Mission will be implemented in 29 districts during 2026-27 on an outlay of ₹7.61 crore allocated from the State's funds.

Vedaanta Senior Living plans ₹800-cr expansion

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Bengaluru-based Vedaanta Senior Living plans to invest ₹800 crore over the next three years to nearly double its footprint across South India. The company, which currently operates 11 active communities housing around 1,000 families, plans to expand to 24 active communities with a capacity for 2,500 families by 2029.

Of the proposed investment, approximately ₹450 crore will be spent in Tamil Nadu, ₹200 crore in Kerala and the balance will be allocated to Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, KB Babu, Director of Services at Vedaanta Senior Living, told *businessline*.

As it enters its next phase of expansion, Vedaanta Senior Living is evaluating strategic external capital to accelerate growth and strengthen its presence across South India amid rising demand for organised retirement communities, said Babu.

In the last 11 years, the company has invested ₹450 crore in senior living.

NEW PROJECTS

The expansion will cover new projects in Tiruchirappalli, Kancheepuram, Hosur, Madurai and Coimbatore in Tamil Nadu, as well as Hyderabad, Tirupati, Mysuru and Bengaluru. In Kerala, the company plans to expand into Thrissur, Kottayam, Thiruvananthapuram, Thiruvalla and Kochi, he added. Vedaanta currently has communities in Coimbatore, Chennai, Hosur, Bengaluru, Kochi and Guruvayur. While

active senior living remains its core business, Vedaanta is expanding into assisted living at Coimbatore and Bengaluru to meet evolving customer requirements.

Among its new initiatives is The Together Community in Hosur which, Babu said, is the country's first-of-its-kind integrated residential community designed for adults with autism and their ageing parents.

Babu urged governments to provide policy support to

the sector, noting that the new government in Kerala had established a dedicated senior citizens' department.

He mentioned that Tamil Nadu pioneered the senior living segment and emphasised that the State government should collaborate with the private sector.

Organised retirement housing still has only single-digit market penetration, despite the industry growing at around 26 per cent annually.

CHAMIER'S ROAD

SPACE FOR RENT

4,400 SQ.FT PER FLOOR

☎ 98840 47171

A **TATA** PRODUCT

TANEIRA

Aadi Sale

upto 40% off*

Sarees | Kurtas | Kurta Sets | Blouses | Dress Materials

Shop online at **TANEIRA**.com

TATACLIQ

Myntra

amazon

SHOPPERS STOP
Chetput, Chennai

f taneirasarees

ig taneira_sarees

whatsapp +91 8147 349 464

Shop on call 1800 266 0123

CHENNAI: Pondy Bazaar: Mena Kampala Arcade (Old Globus Building), Near Residency Hotel, Ph: 9962193123 | **Anna Nagar:** W-100, W-Block, Second Avenue, Opposite to City Tower Hospital, Ph: 8867795909 | **Velachery:** No. 35, 100 ft Road, Opposite Sree Gupta Bhavan, Ph: 7418666488 | **Adyar:** Shop No. 31-15, Ceebros Enclave, 1st Main Road, Gandhi Nagar, Opposite Police Booth, Ph: 9884440103

Enquire about our purchase plan

GoldenCocoon

Own Your Dream Weave

CMVK

🌓

🌓

🌓

🌓

🌈

🌈

🌈

🌈

🌈

M CH-CHE

QUICKLY.

FDA approves first mRNA flu shot from Moderna



The US Food and Drug Administration has approved Moderna's flu vaccine for people aged 50 and older, the company said, marking the first approval of a messenger RNA-based vaccine for seasonal flu. The shot, mFlusiva, was given a traditional approval for adults aged 50 to 64, and an accelerated approval for those 65 years and older. REUTERS

Akasa Air secures ₹740 cr ECLGS loan from IndusInd

Mumbai: Akasa Air has secured ₹740 crore working capital loan from IndusInd Bank under the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS). The Mumbai-headquartered airline is the second carrier after SpiceJet to avail itself of funding under the scheme approved by the Union Cabinet in May to shore up airlines' liquidity. OUR BUREAU

Govt cuts online content takedown time to 2 hours



New Delhi: The government has slashed the online content takedown time for sensitive matters to two hours from the earlier 24 given to social media platforms, an official statement said. Amendments were made on February 10, 2026, to the IT Rules, 2021, to strengthen the regulatory framework to address harms arising from synthetically generated information, including deepfakes and AI-generated content. PTI

TRAI's 5G slicing norms convoluted, may hurt regular users, say experts

LOOPHOLES FLAGGED. Analysts suggest sustainable method is to promote capacity with lower priced spectrum

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Telecom industry representatives have raised doubts regarding the enforcement of the 5G slicing norms proposed in the latest consultation paper released by the sector regulator. As telcos like Bharti Airtel push forward with a slicing-based priority postpaid plan, the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) has released a consultation paper for 5G slicing with network capacity as its driving principle. However, after an initial welcome response, industry experts flagged loopholes in the norms that could ultimately hurt regular, non-premium users. Many experts focused on the suggestion that the base stations of a tower must stay at 80 per cent capacity, measured using a physical resource block (PRB). The paper said that any base station



THRESHOLD ISSUE. TRAI's consultation paper said that any base station that is considered "congested" will need either increased capacity or a complete removal from the slicing model

with over 80 per cent capacity will be considered "congested" and will need either increased capacity or a complete removal from the slicing model. Analysts warned this could lead to monetisation of congestion.

CAPACITY CONGESTION "TRAI does not specify how many PRBs are dedicated to one or the other category of users. The congestion will include premium users and ordinary users. How will you ensure that premium users

will not eat away capacity speed of ordinary users? That is not written anywhere," said Parag Kar, telecom expert. Further, he explained in his video how the 80 per cent capacity is an aggregate figure for all PRBs in a tower as opposed to minimum capacity of every PRB. This means that some base stations may circumvent the TRAI threshold entirely. "One bad hotspot can disappear within the LSA," said Kar. Further, Faisal Kawoosa,

Chief Analyst and Founder of Techarc argued that the current paper seems self-contradictory. "If operators are able to maintain 80 per cent capacity in this way, there would be no need of plans like Fastlane. If this is implemented, they will have to deprioritise someone and it will not be premium users," he said.

MAPPING NORMS Aside from the slicing norms, the paper also called for better mapping details in terms of network coverage by operators. This means that the TRAI network map will come with added context of labels such as 'excellent', 'good', 'fair' and no coverage. This will help the users understand coverage weaknesses better. Yet, even with these positioned norms, analysts questioned the enforceability and redressal mechanisms in the paper. "My concern is how will the government ensure en-

forcement of these parameters. The paper does not mention a grievance redressal mechanism. How will the regulator deploy penalties and sanction if the quality of service is poor. There should be mechanism to enforce it especially as we head towards a duopoly with around 80 per cent market share among two players," said V Sridhar, Professor at IIT-Bangalore.

LIMITED RESOURCES Ultimately, the biggest hindrance to a 5G slicing resolution lies in India's limited resources. According to Kar, operators have no incentive to provide quality service, which is the biggest challenge. "The sustainable method is to promote capacity with lower priced spectrum, lower taxes, lower licence fees, improved competition and better transparency which motivates operators to offer good services," said Kar.

Gebremariam — A turnaround specialist

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Ethiopian Airlines faced its toughest test in March 2019 following a fatal air crash involving a Boeing 737 Max aircraft that also raised questions about pilot training. As the airline came under scrutiny, group CEO Tewolde Gebremariam put out a message dispelling the doubts related to its training standards.



Tewolde Gebremariam, CEO, Air India

SPOTLIGHT.

"In a nation that is sometimes saddled with negative stereotypes, accidents like this affect our sense of pride. Yet this tragedy won't define us," he wrote. It didn't. Ethiopian Airlines grew its network, increased revenue and made a profit too, albeit smaller one compared to the previous financial year. The airline also began drafting a Vision 2035 document.

Gebremariam, who led Ethiopian Airlines from 2011-2022, was on Wednesday named as Air India's new Chief Executive Officer. He replaces Campbell Wilson.

PROVEN RECORD An economic and a business administration graduate, Gebremariam rose through the ranks to occupy the top post in Ethiopian Airlines. He has worked in India before serving as the airline's regional director before taking up assignments in Saudi Arabia and the US. "Tewolde was part of the executive team under former CEO Girma Wake that developed Ethiopian's 'Vision 2025' long-term plan in the late 2000s. He then executed the plan after he took over as CEO in 2011 and nearly quadrupled the airline revenues in the decade that followed," said Sean Mendis, an aviation consultant, who has worked in senior roles in various African airlines. Ethiopian Airlines emerged as the largest air-

line in Africa under his tenure doubling its destinations to 128. Annual revenue grew from \$1 billion to \$5 billion and airline posted a net profit of \$1 billion in 2022.

Gebremariam stepped down in 2022 citing health reasons. According to his LinkedIn profile, he runs a consultancy service and also serves as a strategic advisor for Delta Airlines. Currently, Ethiopian Airlines has a fleet of 170 aircraft and flies to 145 destinations.

HIGHLY RESPECTED "Gebremariam took a relatively small airline, in a low-income economy with limited origin-destination traffic, and grew it into a hub carrier which is the most profitable in Africa. His experience in driving growth while remaining financially viable will serve him well as will his familiarity with Star Alliance," said Binit Somaia, Director of aviation consultancy CAPA India. Air India has undergone significant improvements in past four years but has emerged as biggest loss maker for Tata Group. Thus for Gebremariam immediate task is to improve airline profitability. Mendis thinks the Ethiopian Airlines former group CEO has the qualities to lead Air India. "Tewolde has solid background and knowledge in commercial, operations and finance so has the ability to hold his own on any of these subjects," Mendis added.

France submits proposal for 114 Rafale jets deal

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Responding to India's letter of request (LoR), France has submitted a detailed proposal for 114 Rafale fighter aircraft worth ₹3.25 lakh crore. The move will roll out the process of formal negotiations between the two countries for commercial and technical negotiations to acquire Rafale jets, which would include local manufacturing of 94 of the 114 multi-role combat fighters in India. The Acquisition Wing of the Ministry of Defence and

the Indian Air Force are together going through the French proposal as the government is pushing hard to localise weapon integration, like variants of Astra air-to-air missile, with the Rafale platform. Ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Paris in June, *businessline* had reported that the Macron government is engaging seriously with India's demand for access to source codes, which would allow the indigenous integration of weapons and systems. Another issue under extensive consideration is India's push to execute the entire project under the 'Make in India'

According to the deal, for the first time 90 of the 114 Rafale jets will be produced in India

procurement policy, French diplomatic sources had then said. **MAKE IN INDIA** "Both the French government and French companies are committed to integrating Make in India into our defence deals, including the Rafale," sources had stated. As per the government-to-

government deal, for the first time 90 of the 114 Rafale jets will be produced in India, marking a significant shift from the two earlier Rafale contracts with France. When India purchased 36 Rafales for the Indian Air Force (IAF) in 2016 and another 26 marine versions last year, all aircraft were acquired in 100 per cent fly-away condition — they were built, assembled and tested entirely in France by Dassault Aviation. In May, India issued the LoR to France inviting comprehensive proposal for the Rafale jet deal for the IAF. Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh had earlier

stated that Dassault Aviation had offered 40 per cent localisation during initial discussions. But, according to him, the Ministry of Defence is pushing for 50 per cent or more. For the first time, the aircraft will be manufactured outside of France and in India. The proposed acquisition is meant to even out depleting squadron strength of IAF fighter aircraft. As of now, IAF has an existing fleet of 32 squadrons against the requirement of 40 squadrons to fight a two-front war. The Rafales from the proposed deal are expected to start coming to India from 2029-30.

EVERY GREAT JOURNEY BEGINS WITH ONE DECISION.

ONE THAT DEFINES EVERY MILE TO COME.

THE PRESIDENTIAL LIMOUSINE

SECURE AN ASSURED **60% BUYBACK** AT THE END OF **3 YEARS.***
ENJOY **DEPRECIATION BENEFITS** OF **UP TO 40%.***

EMI starting at **₹88,888#**
www.mgselect.co.in

CHENNAI: 9240940492, Door No. 428, Anna Salai, CIT Nagar East, Nandanam, Chennai - 600035

*Buyback value is insured by Zuno General Insurance. Lockton India is the Insurance Broker. T&C apply
*Disclaimer: All prices are ex-showroom India. Actual performance figures may differ in conditions other than test conditions. Vehicle body colour may differ due to printing process. Images used in this ad are for representation purposes only. In view of our policy of continuously improving our products, we reserve the right to alter specifications, features, and designs without prior notice and without liability. All models are subject to availability. Please check details with your nearest MG Select Dealer Partner for latest information. Accessories and features shown in the pictures may not be a part of standard equipment and will differ according to the variant. Available pan-India. *T&C Apply. #EMI is indicative and subject to financier's sole discretion. Terms and conditions apply.

